



ODISHA SIR

20 lakh names deleted as draft rolls published

NEWS » PAGE 8

FIFA WORLD CUP

Mbappe puts France in last eight

SPORT » PAGE 13





FIRST INSTALMENT

₹25,863 crore released under VB-G RAM G

NEWS » PAGE 9

DATA POINT

Hype around U.P.'s 'revenue surplus'

Inability of the State to spend its budget leading to surplus, show data

OPINION » PAGE 7



'VIOLENT FIGHTING'

Houthi attack kills 22 pro-govt. Yemen troops

WORLD » PAGE 12

NEARBY



'Minister trying to dilute Karur stampede case'

SALEM
AIADMK deputy general secretary K.P. Munusamy on Sunday claimed that Minister for Public Works Aadhav Arjuna was trying to dilute the Karur stampede case. » PAGE 4

GCC to raise fine for waste disposal rules violation

CHENNAI
The Greater Chennai Corporation is likely to start collecting a fine of ₹25,000 from bulk waste generators who violate the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026. Currently, most violators pay a fine of ₹5,000. » PAGE 3

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 2 & 15

Govt. issues notice to Meta on 'child sexual abuse' ads

Instagram, owned by Meta, ordered to disable advertisements promoting explicit child content and provide explanation within seven days; 'further action' to be decided after reviewing reply

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology has directed Meta, the parent body of several social media platforms, to disable advertisements and content promoting and facilitating access to child sexual exploitative and abuse material (CSEAM) on Instagram, according to government sources. It has also sought an explanation on the issue.

"The Ministry has ordered Instagram to disable such advertisements. The government has also demanded a detailed explanation on the action taken and other relevant information within seven days. A notice in this regard was issued on Saturday," said a

Unsafe space

The notice comes amid allegations that Meta's algorithm had been promoting videos with child sexual abuse material on its platforms

The government has demanded a detailed explanation from the corporation on actions taken against the advertisements and other relevant information within seven days

Instagram is alleged to have shown paid advertisements with child sexual abuse material which directed users to Telegram channels where such content was reportedly on sale

Meta's advertisement policy prohibits content with sexually suggestive activities

Meta is in a 'constant battle with criminals who hide among our 3.5 billion users and try to evade detection', a spokesperson said

source. It is learnt that the notice was sent following a directive from IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw to senior Ministry officials. Further course of action will be decided after reviewing the reply, said the source.

The move came a day af

ter the BBC Eye published its investigation revealing that Instagram had allegedly been running "paid adverts promoting child sexual abuse material in India" and that such advertisements linked users to channels on Telegram, where they could buy the

material. Meta's policy on advertisements, meanwhile, stipulate that their content must comply with community standards and must not have imagery depicting nudity and activities that are sexual or sexually suggestive

In response to a query on the notice, a Meta spokesperson pointed to an earlier statement shared after the BBC report came out, where Meta said it had a "zero tolerance policy for soliciting or sharing CSEAM" and added that while Meta deployed technology to detect such advertisements, it was in a "constant battle with criminals who hide among 3.5 billion users and try to evade detection".

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Emergency gas curbs eased as LNG shipments normalise

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The Union government has withdrawn most provisions of an emergency natural gas supply regulation order following the resumption of liquefied natural gas (LNG) shipments through the Strait of Hormuz.

In a notification issued on Saturday, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas amended the Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order, 2026, omitting key operational provisions which led to all domestically produced natural gas and imported LNG to be sold as per a priority customer list drawn by the government. The original order, issued on March 9 under the Essential Commodities Act, was brought in after the conflict in West Asia disrupted LNG shipments, with suppliers invoking *force majeure* and diverting cargoes to priority consumers.

Restored flow

The gas supply curbs were one of three emergency measures the govt. introduced after energy supplies from the Gulf were threatened by the effective closure of the Strait of Hormuz

- Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order, 2026 was brought in on March 9 with suppliers invoking *force majeure* and diverting cargoes to priority consumers
- Latest amendment omits operational provisions for LNG to be sold as per a new priority customer list drawn by the government from the order
- The other two measures — diverting feedstock to maximise LPG production and restricting bulk sale of diesel — have already been withdrawn

The Ministry said the situation has since improved, with a ceasefire in place, further negotiations under way, and traffic through the Strait of Hormuz resuming.

Emergency measures
The gas supply curbs were one of three emergency measures the government introduced after energy supplies from the Gulf were threatened by the closure of the Strait of Hor-

muz after the crisis broke out with U.S.- Israeli strike on Iran in February.

The other two measures — directing refiners to maximise LPG production by diverting feedstock from petrochemicals and restricting diesel sales to bulk consumers — have already been withdrawn as the supply situation normalised.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Adani case: U.S. DoJ cites 'diplomatic strife'

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The U.S. Department of Justice (DoJ) has cited possible "diplomatic strife" to justify its move to drop all charges against Indian industrialist Gautam Adani, his nephew Sagar Adani, and their associates over securities fraud allegations.

The indictments against the Adanis and associates pertain to a foreign case and the U.S.'s actions as "world police can cause diplomatic strife", the DoJ said on Saturday, adding that "not a penny has been lost" due to the alleged fraud. "This is a foreign case... several Indians (with maybe a European or



Gautam Adani

two) allegedly tried to bribe other Indians by paying the Indian government via complex Indian rebate programs to get Indian contracts to provide electricity in India," said a 10-page note submitted by the DoJ to a U.S. court.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Mourning in Tehran



Farewell prayers: Iranians gather to pray for the country's slain Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei during the second day of funeral ceremonies at the Grand Mosalla in Tehran on Sunday. AFP (REPORT: PAGE 12)

Many G.O.s unavailable on T.N. govt. website

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Only five of the 38 departments have published their government orders (G.O.s) on the Tamil Nadu government website after the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) assumed office on May 10.

The Departments of Rural Development and Panchayat Raj, Health and Family Welfare, Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection, Finance, and Public can be called "outliers" as they have hosted their G.O.s issued in May and June on the website.

The orders that are not available on the site pertain to some of the high-

profile measures such as the creation of the Singaperumal Special Force and the provision of 100 additional units of electricity to domestic consumers who use 500 units bi-monthly. Interestingly, the G.O.s on these measures are otherwise available in the public domain.

As for the waiver of crop loans taken by farmers from cooperative societies, the G.O. on the extension of the relief is available on the 'What's New' section and the Tamil version of the 'Government Orders' section of the Department of Co-operation, Food and Consumer Protection.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 4

Three dead, four injured as rain pounds Mumbai and other parts of Maharashtra

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Three people were killed and four injured as torrential rain lashed Maharashtra on Sunday, affecting life in Mumbai, Thane, and several other districts.

Flight operations at Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport in Mumbai were affected for about an hour due to heavy rain and strong winds.

Several rain-related incidents were reported from different parts of the State. Yunus Kundawala, 63, died after a tree fell on him in Mumbai. The death took the monsoon-related toll in the city to three over the past week.

The Maharashtra Disaster Management Authority



Damaged vehicles in the Mahim region in Mumbai as trees fell on them during heavy rain on Sunday. EMMANUAL YOGINI

said that one person was killed and four were injured in Satara in rain-related incidents, while a teenager drowned in a swollen river in Thane.

In Raigad district, which was on red alert, over 12 tourists were safely rescued from Adoshi waterfall near Khopoli with the help

of the police after the water level rose sharply following heavy rain. A massive landslide on the road leading to Rajmachi Fort completely blocked vehicle traffic in Lonavala and earth movers were deployed to clear the debris, the police said.

Mumbai city recorded

265.6 mm rainfall in the 24 hours ending at 4 p.m. on Sunday, the highest in the State for the day.

The Thane Regional Disaster Management Cell received 93 complaints during the last 24 hours, including 46 instances of fallen trees and branches, 24 instances of waterlogging, eight compound wall collapses, and one landslide. Several low-lying areas in Thane city, Kalyan, Bhiwandi, Ulhasnagar, Dombivli, and Navi Mumbai were flooded and water entered homes in many of these areas.

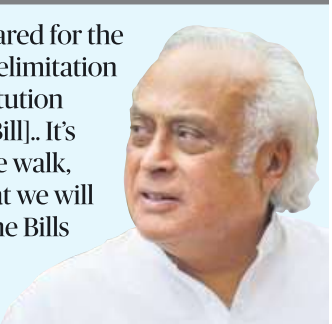
The administration has issued a warning asking people to stay indoors in districts which are on orange and red alert on Monday. (With agency inputs)

Govt. pushing 'dangerous', 'diabolical' Bills, Opposition prepared, says Jairam Ramesh

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

Ahead of the upcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament, the Congress exuded confidence that the united Opposition would once again be able to stall the Delimitation Bill, if the government were to bring it back, as well as the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill, 2025, which seeks the automatic dismissal of the Prime Minister, Chief Ministers, and Ministers if they are arrested and detained for 30 consecutive days.

Calling the former "dangerous" and the latter "diabolical", Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh, speaking to *The Hindu*,



We are prepared for the 2-D Bills — Delimitation and Dismissal [Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill]. It's going to be a tightrope walk, but I am confident that we will be able to stop both the Bills

JAIRAM RAMESH
Congress leader

said the government did not have the numbers, despite the split in the Trinamool Congress and the Shiv Sena (UBT). "We are prepared for the 2-D Bills — Delimitation and Dismissal," Mr. Ramesh said, referring to the Constitution (130th Amendment) Bill as the "dismissal Bill".

On April 17, the united Opposition defeated the

Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026, which sought to redistribute Lok Sabha seats on the basis of the 2011 Census to expedite the implementation of women's reservation.

"If you go by what happened that day, there were 528 members in the Lok Sabha who voted on the Bill. To pass the Bill, the government needed a two-

thirds majority, which put the number at 352. As opposed to 352, the government got 298. Now they claim they have 324, which means they are still significantly short," Mr. Ramesh said. He further alleged that the government could arrange for abstentions to bring down the majority mark. "I am not putting it past them, but even if they arrange for abstentions, they are still substantially short of the required number," Mr. Ramesh said.

Calling the recent split in the Trinamool and the Shiv Sena (UBT) a serious setback, Mr. Ramesh said all Opposition parties continued to be in touch.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

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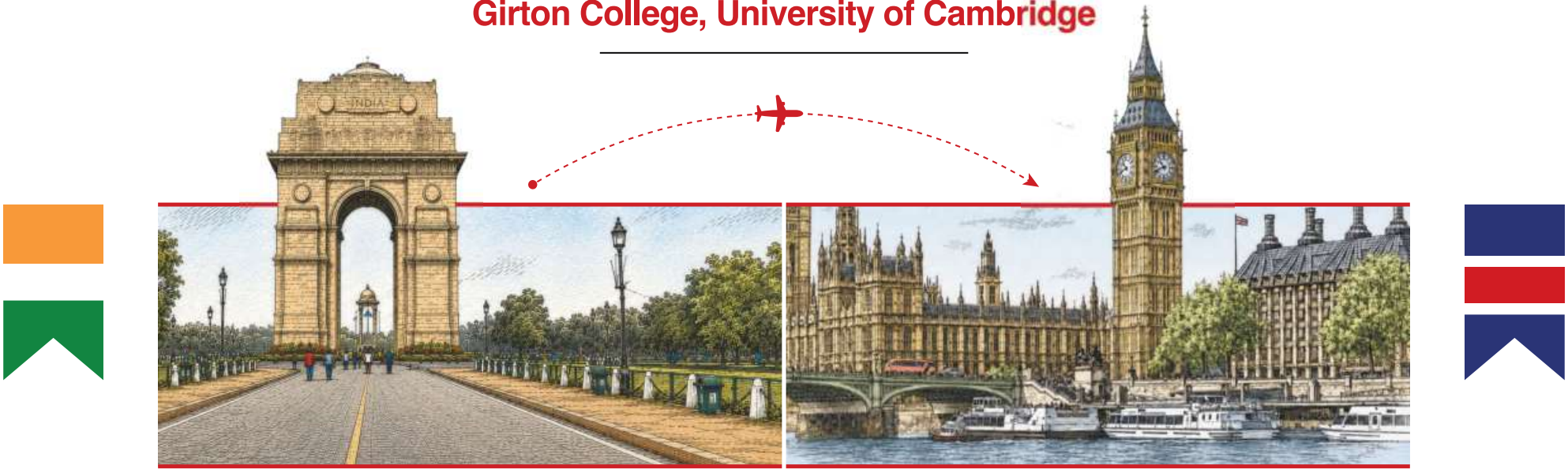
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INBRIEF



VIT Chennai holds induction programme for law students

Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT), Chennai, held its induction programme for students joining law degree programmes at the VIT School of Law. The chief guest for the event was Justice Devan Ramachandran, Judge of the Kerala High Court. The other guests were Sarah Sunny, advocate, Supreme Court of India, and Maygha Viswanat, senior legal counsel at XFLOW Payments India Private Limited and an alumna of the VIT School of Law, proposed a vote of thanks. P.K. Manoharan, Additional Registrar, Nithya Darisini P. S., Dean (Academics); and A. Nayeemulla Khan, Dean (Academic Research), participated.

Registration of properties has become easy, says Minister

The registration of properties has become easy and hassle-free under the TVK-led government, said Minister for Food and Civil Supplies P. Venkataramanan. Speaking at the launch of a book, *Vizhuntha Manithargal*, in the city on Sunday, he recalled his days as a lawyer when he had to visit Sub Registrar Offices for registration of properties for his clients. Minister for Commercial Taxes and Registration D. Logesh Tamilselvan recalled his association with Prakash M. Swamy, the author of the book. Former Minister H.V. Hande, Jawaharlal Nehru University Vice-Chancellor Santishree D. Pandit, founder of Gem Granites R. Veeramani, spiritual orator P. Manikandan, eye surgeon Ganesh B., and chartered accountant Ravishankar also spoke. In his speech, Mr. Swamy recalled his experience working for various media organisations.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (July 6, Monday), the following articles are available:

- The real crisis in India's fisheries [newsth.live/indiasfisheries](#)
- Milk production in Gangetic plains has nosedived due to climate change [newsth.live/milkprod](#)

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.



Commuters waiting at the Park Railway Station on Sunday. R. RAGU

Commuters put to hardship as Southern Railway cancels 41 suburban services

The Hindu Bureau

CHENNAI

Hundreds of suburban commuters faced severe hardships on Sunday after Southern Railway cancelled 41 suburban train services from Beach to Tambaram and Chengalpattu. The train services were cancelled for undertaking engineering works as part of safety measures. While the Chennai division operated special trains to compensate for the cancelled services from 10.30 a.m. to 3.30 p.m., the trains were operated only between Tambaram and Chengalpattu, re-

sulting in heavy crowds waiting in several railway stations including Park, Egmore, Fort, and Mambalam. The Metropolitan Transport Corporation (MTC) also operated 50 additional bus services from Tambaram to various destinations. S. Vikram, a resident of Palavanthangal, said that suburban trains are already crowded on Sundays due to reduced schedules. The five-hour service cancellation forces outstation travellers, as well as passengers proceeding to the Dr. MGR Chennai Central station, to depend on commercial vehicles.

THE HINDU
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CITY MATTERS

Aloysius Xavier Lopez

CHENNAI

As the regulation of bulk waste generators remains a challenge, the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) is likely to start collecting a fine of ₹25000 from bulk waste generators who violate the Solid Waste Management Rules 2026, in a few months. Currently, most of the violators pay a fine of ₹5000.

Over 43% of the bulk waste generators including large apartment complexes, commercial buildings, hospitals, industries, and IT parks in the city have not registered in the centralised portal of Chennai Corporation and Central Pollution Control Board.

Chennai Corporation Commissioner G.S. Sameeran has ordered the officials to identify all bulk waste generators of solid waste in the city for hand holding ahead of the launch of enforcement drive across the city. "GCC intends to handhold the bulk waste generators for a few months. If they continue to violate the rules, we will collect a fine," he said.

Following Supreme Court's direction, each district will constitute a special cell to monitor compliance with the rules and,



Strict action: A total penalty of ₹5.95 lakh was collected from 120 bulk waste generators in the city between June 1 and June 30 for violation of the rules. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

wherever necessary, issue appropriate directions, including disconnection of water and electricity supply to bulk waste generators who violate the rules.

Of the 3,204 bulk waste generators identified in Chennai, 1,803 buildings have registered in the online portal of the GCC. The percentage of online registration for monitoring of the buildings including large residential apartments is less than 30% in zones such as Tiruvottiyur, Manali, Madhavaram, Royapuram, and Alandur. The percentage is more than 80% in zones such as Thiru. Vi. Ka. Nagar, Ambattur, Anna Nagar, Adyar, and Sholinganallur.

As per the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026, any institution or establish-

ment that satisfies any one of the following criteria shall be classified as a bulk waste generator: A building having a total built-up area of 20,000 sq. m. or more; or an establishment with a daily water consumption of 40,000 litres or more; or an institution or establishment generating 100 kg or more of solid waste per day.

As per the above definition, institutional establishments, commercial establishments, residential welfare associations, hotels, hospitals, educational institutions, IT parks, marriage halls, commercial complexes, markets, industries, and other large establishments are all covered under the category of bulk waste generators.

According to a press re-

lease from GCC on Sunday, pursuant of the provisions of the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026, instructions have been issued to all bulk waste generators within the jurisdiction of the Greater Chennai Corporation.

All bulk waste generators shall mandatorily register through the Greater Chennai Corporation website on both the Greater Chennai Corporation and Central Pollution Control Board portals available on the website within 15 days from July 5.

During the period from June 1 to June 30, a total penalty of ₹5.95 lakh was imposed and collected from 120 bulk waste generators for violation of the rules.

Bulk waste generators shall procure the required

colour-coded bins and ensure segregation of waste at source. The segregated waste shall be placed at the entrance to the premises and handed over to the Corporation or an agency authorised by the GCC.

Bulk waste generators shall process the biodegradable (wet) waste generated within their premises through composting, bio-methanation (biogas generation), or any other environmentally sustainable method approved under the Solid Waste Management Rules, 2026.

Bulk waste generators shall maintain proper records of waste generation, processing, transportation, and final disposal, and shall submit quarterly reports through the online portals of the Chennai Corporation, and the Central Pollution Control Board.

The registration portals for Central Pollution Control Board and the GCC are <https://swm.cpcb.gov.in/register> and <https://gccservices.in/bulkwaste/register> respectively.

In all GCC zones, the personnel nominated by the respective Zonal Officers, Swachh Bharat Mission Animators, and Independent Engineers shall provide necessary assistance to bulk waste generators for online registration, and uploading the required information on the registration portal.

Over 1.6 lakh teachers write eligibility test paper-II in T.N.

The Hindu Bureau

CHENNAI

As many as 1,60,929 teachers across the State wrote the paper-II of the Teachers Eligibility Test on Sunday.

The paper-I, conducted on Saturday, was for teachers handling Classes I-V, and the one held on Sunday was for teachers of Classes VI-VIII and those who want to qualify for promotions. A total of 1,02,51 candidates had registered to appear for paper-II in 38 examination centers in Chennai.

While teachers said that Sunday's question paper was much easier than Saturday's, they pointed out that there had not been enough time to prepare for the examination. "The TET paper-I was very tough. Compared to it, this was an easier paper, but questions were also asked from the syllabus of Classes XI and X," a teacher from Chennai said.

According to a press release from the Teachers Recruitment Board, a total of 1,67,743 teachers had registered to take up the exam. A total of 6,814 were absent for the examination.

"We had qualified through another competitive exam to become teachers. The government is putting us through this ordeal again. The government could at least relax the qualifying marks," another teacher said.

Chennai Weather

	max	min
Tiruvallur	35	25
Chennai Airport	35	23
Chennai City	34	25

Chennai Airport Today
37°C The weather will be mostly dry. The day will be very warm and uneasy. The night also will be uneasy.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
38°C The morning will be comfortable. The day will be slightly hot and uneasy. The night also will be uneasy. Mostly dry weather to prevail.

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PUBLIC NOTICE

ENVIRONMENTAL AND CRZ CLEARANCE FOR THE PROPOSED PROJECT OF EXPANSION OF ENNORE LNG TERMINAL FROM 5 MMTPA TO 10 MMTPA OF M/s. INDIANOIL LNG PRIVATE LIMITED (IOLPL), ENNORE, THIRUVALLUR DISTRICT, TAMIL NADU.

This is for the information to all concerned that the Project for Expansion of Ennore LNG Terminal of M/s IndianOil LNG Private Limited (IOLPL) from 5 MMTPA to 10 MMTPA at Ennore, Thiruvallur District, Tamil Nadu has been granted prior Environmental and CRZ Clearance (EC) by the Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change, IA Division, Government of India, New Delhi vide letter File No. 11-30/2011-IA.II dated 29.06.2026.

A copy of the Clearance Letter is available with the Tamil Nadu State Pollution Control Board and may also be viewed on the website of The Ministry of Environment, Forests and Climate Change at <https://parivesh.nic.in>, and on the Company's website at www.indianoillng.com

Chief Executive Officer,
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CINEMA • ARTS • EVENTS

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Today 5.30 p.m at R.K. Swamy Auditorium Mylapore Bharathanatyam by Students of Smt. Uma Dinesh 7 p.m. Bharathanatyam by Kum. MAHIMA SRIDHAR (Dis. of Smt. Ashwini Viswanathan).

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I, **SAIGNANENDER** S/O Raman R/O H. No. 32/7, Jeeva Nagar, Thorapadi, Dist. Vellore (Tamil Nadu) - 632002 have changed the name of my minor son S Vignesh Karthick aged 5 years and he shall hereafter be known as PERUMALA ADHITHYA S.

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Published by Nirmala Lakshman at Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002 on behalf of THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. and Printed by Ra Babu Vijay at THG PUBLISHING PVT.LTD. Plot B-6 & B-7, CMDA Industrial Complex, Maraimalai Nagar, Chengalpattu Taluk, Chengalpattu Dist., Pin 603209. Editor: Suresh Nambath Chandrasekar (Responsible for selection of news under the PRP Act). ISSN 0971 - 751X

CMYK A CH-CHE

Chennai Corpn. yet to clear ₹2,000-cr. dues for completed works

The GCC cuts down on expenses and intensifies property tax collection; Deputy Mayor seeks allocations under special funds to ease the pressure

R. Aishwaryaa
CHENNAI

With outstanding payments of around ₹2,000 crore for completed works yet to be cleared, the Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has tightened its belt in an attempt to cut down expenditure and intensified property tax collection to increase revenue.

Deputy Mayor M. Magesh Kumar said that of the ₹2,000-crore pending amount, about ₹450 crore was owed to Urbaser Sum-eet, one of the private firms outsourced to handle solid waste management, he said. He urged GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran to request Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to consider releasing allocations under special funds to ease the pressure.

Standing Committee (Taxation and Finance) Chairperson Sarbajaya Das said the GCC would assess under-assessed commercial and other large properties, including those measuring over 2,000 sq.ft. and 3,000 sq.ft., using GIS-based data to improve tax collection. But, many large-scale projects are on hold, she added.

According to a senior official, the GCC has doubled its daily property tax collection target from ₹5 crore



Financial crunch:The GCC has so far collected around ₹500 crore against its half-year property tax demand of about ₹980 crore.

to ₹10 crore to improve its own-source revenue.

Against the current half-year demand of about ₹980 crore, roughly ₹500 crore has been collected as of July 1. Additional staff have been deployed, more point-of-sale devices have been provided, and collection hours extended for door-to-door collection of arrears, he added.

“The current financial pressure is temporary. The GCC expects its financial position to improve by September, when further development projects could be considered,” the official said.

“GCC’s priority now is to ensure that no worker, including those in conservancy and NULM [National Urban Livelihoods Mission], loses a month’s salary. We have kept conser-

vancy workers’ wages aside, so capital projects will proceed slowly,” the official told *The Hindu*.

The GCC decided to slow down spending on new projects and make payments to contractors in stages with the Trade Receivables Discounting System. Contractors can obtain early advances through the Receivables Exchange of India Limited, the official said.

“The GCC receives ₹80-₹82 crore every month through State Finance Commission devolution. About ₹360 crore towards three quarters of stamp duty and surcharge is yet to be released by the State. We have requested the State government to release these dues. Beyond this, funds cannot be expected from the State,” he said.

AI-powered tools can trace missing persons faster, with more accuracy, say experts

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

Cybersecurity researchers are advocating the use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) powered tools to help trace missing persons more quickly and efficiently.

While conventional investigations largely rely on human intelligence, witness accounts, technical evidence, and surveillance camera footage, cyber forensics experts say AI can significantly improve both the speed and accuracy of investigations, especially when time is critical.

Thousands of people, including women and children, are reported missing across the country every year. According to the National Crime Records Bureau data, 4,24,235 people reported missing – including 2,64,934 women and 13 transgender persons – remain untraced. In Tamil Nadu alone, 5,524 missing persons are yet to be located.

G. Deepak Raj Rao, Professor, National Forensic Sciences University, Chennai, said AI systems could process information at a scale and speed impossible for humans to match. Police investigations were often constrained by limited manpower, making it impractical for investigators to simultaneously monitor video feeds from multiple surveillance cameras. AI systems, however, could analyse thousands of hours of CCTV footage in real time, detect movement



In Tamil Nadu, 5,524 missing persons are yet to be located.

patterns and generate alerts when a missing person’s identity is matched.

“The longer it takes to locate a missing person, the greater the challenges. Every minute counts when it comes to the person’s safety and movement. In the case of a missing child, the first 24 to 48 hours are critical. In remote or under-resourced areas where police personnel are over-stretched, AI-assisted tools can produce results within minutes, whereas conventional methods may take several days,” he said.

Facial recognition

Modern facial recognition systems can identify individuals across CCTV networks installed at public places such as shopping malls and transport hubs. AI can also detect and flag even partial images of missing persons appearing in social media posts, news reports or other publicly available content for further probe.

Dr. Deepak said that in a majority of missing-person cases, particularly those in-

volving young people, valuable digital footprints are often available. AI can scan social media platforms for last-known activity, location tags, and accounts linked to the missing individual. It can also analyse social media history to identify signs of emotional distress and map relationship networks to help investigators identify persons of interest.

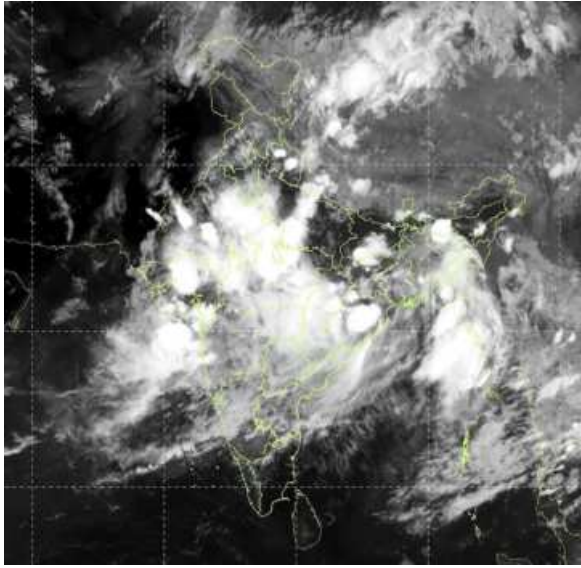
Senthil Kumar Ilango, a researcher studying AI applications in cybersecurity and investigations, said AI tools could analyse terrain, weather conditions, the person’s last-known location and behavioural patterns to prioritise search areas. He said one of the major challenges was the absence of a common platform to integrate information from multiple systems.

“For instance, a person admitted to a hospital could be the individual police are searching for in a neighbouring district or State. But there is no mechanism to connect the dots. AI-powered integration platforms could automatically match unidentified individuals against missing-person records across jurisdictions,” Mr. Senthil Kumar said.

Officials of Southern Railway said facial recognition cameras and AI-assisted surveillance tools were expected to be deployed at railway stations to help identify missing persons as well as monitor individuals with criminal antecedents.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy to very heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Chhattisgarh, Gujarat, Goa, Maharashtra, East Rajasthan, Himachal Pradesh, Karnataka, Kerala & Mahe, Lakshadweep, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, and Uttarakhand.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	4.0	31.5	26.4	Kurnool	2.0	34.3	26.2
Ahmedabad	29.0	35.4	23.6	Lucknow	15.0	39.0	30.2
Aizawl	0.2	33.3	23.9	Madurai	—	—	—
Bengaluru	0.5	29.0	20.9	Mangaluru	5.8	30.4	24.2
Bhopal	1.2	32.2	25.4	Mumbai	227.7	27.5	24.5
Bhubaneswar	0.3	28.4	24.5	Mysuru	—	29.0	20.0
Chandigarh	1.5	37.1	26.9	New Delhi	—	38.6	29.2
Chennai	—	39.0	28.6	Patna	—	0.4	35.8
Coimbatore	—	32.2	23.4	Port Blair	1.3	31.0	25.0
Dehradun	0.8	33.2	25.3	Prayagraj	—	38.4	30.1
Gangtok	11.0	33.6	17.7	Puducherry	—	35.6	26.0
Goa	22.2	31.0	25.6	Pune	—	33.4	28.0
Guwahati	3.4	35.7	25.9	Raipur	—	154.4	26.1
Hubballi	—	26.1	22.2	Ranchi	—	12.0	28.0
Hyderabad	0.7	30.0	24.0	Shillong	—	1.7	27.4
Imphal	1.0	29.8	24.5	Shimla	—	8.4	27.5
Jaipur	—	38.4	24.5	Srinagar	—	34.4	19.8
Kochi	2.8	30.6	24.0	Thiruvananthapuram	—	30.7	31.8
Kohima	—	—	—	Tiruchirappalli	—	—	37.7
Kolkata	0.3	30.0	27.4	Vijayawada	—	4.9	34.0
Kozhikode	6.0	33.2	25.2	Visakhapatnam	—	17.8	29.8

Pollutants in the air you are breathing							Yesterday
CITIES	SO ₂	NO _x	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Dholpur, Rajasthan recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 280 indicating an unhealthy level of pollution. In contrast, Beed, Maharashtra recorded a healthy AQI score of 16.
Ahmedabad	30	11	48	23	75	5	
Bengaluru	5	8	—	28	87	3	
Chennai	1	13	—	28	141	2	
Delhi	4	17	44	238	141	1	
Hyderabad	8	13	28	44	57	4	
Kolkata	18	20	90	70	84	3	
Lucknow	9	29	35	49	89	3	
Mumbai	7	21	78	26	31	2	
Pune	37	72	28	31	—	2	
Visakhapatnam	27	59	33	63	—	2	

Air Quality Code: 1 Poor 2 Moderate 3 Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO_x: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Shiv Das Meena resigns as TNRERA chairperson

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Former Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer Shiv Das Meena, who was the Chairperson of the Tamil Nadu Real Estate Regulatory Authority (TNRE-RA), and two other members of the statutory body – L. Subramanian and Sukumar Chittibabu – have submitted their resignations to the State government. They were appointed by the previous DMK government.

Official sources said Mr. Meena, a 1989-batch officer of Tamil Nadu cadre who was appointed to the post on August 18, 2024, stepped down recently.

Mylapore Fine Arts Club’s drama festival inaugurated

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Mylapore Fine Arts Club conferred the title ‘Nataka Kala Nipuna’ on director, producer, and stage actor ‘Mapillai’ Ganesh here on Sunday.

While speaking at the inauguration of the club’s 22nd year Drama Festival, Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti, industrialist and president of The Mylapore Fine Arts Club, said Mr. Ganesh would get under the skin of a character, and his co-artists too gave life to the characters they played. His dramas centred around the events that occurred in a family, allowing audiences to relate to them.

Theatre director Bombay Chanakya said that for



Club president Nalli Kuppuswami Chetti presenting an award to stage actor ‘Mapillai’ Ganesh on Sunday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

the last 22 years, The Mylapore Fine Arts Club had been honouring and encouraging drama artists.

‘Committed artiste’

He said Mr. Ganesh began his career in 1981 and for the last 45 years, he has been successful in this field. He has also been running his drama troupe sincerely for the last 25

years. “Mr. Ganesh is a dependable and a committed artiste,” Mr. Chanakya added.

After accepting the honour, Mr. Ganesh said that for any theatre artiste, receiving such awards and gaining appreciation from the audience truly went a long way in encouraging and pushing them to do more.

Ammonia gas removal operation at Tiruvallur factory to continue today

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The process of pumping out ammonia gas from St. Peter and Paul Pvt. Ltd., a seafood processing unit at Kannigaipair in Tiruvallur district, will continue on Monday.

The unit witnessed a leak of the toxic gas on June 21, which left 18 workers dead and many hospitalised.

Collector S. Kavitha said that the operation would continue until the gas is completely removed.

The same safety proto-

cols will be in place and medical teams, along with ambulances and the police and Fire and Rescue Services personnel, will be on standby.

Work to remove ammonia was carried out by a team of industry experts from 9 a.m. to 5 p.m. on Sa-

turday and Sunday.

According to safety protocols, such evacuations are best carried out during the daytime, as ammonia spreads faster at night when the temperatures are lower. Additionally, the teams would be more alert during the day.

Man booked in goat theft case appointed government pleader in Tirupattur court

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUPATTUR

A practising advocate, who had been booked in a goat theft case, has been appointed as a government pleader at a District and Sessions Court in Tirupattur town by the State government, inviting public outcry.

The police said the advocate has been identified as A. Sheik Sulthan, a resident of Vaniyambadi town. He was an advocate at the District Munsif Court in Vaniyambadi.

Initial inquiry revealed that the complainant, S. Anjala, 65, a resident of Pudhur village near Vaniyambadi town, reared goats for a living. She filed a complaint with Vaniyam-

Legal experts, however, say only conviction and not mere filing of cases restricts individuals from assuming government posts

badi Town police after she noticed one of her goats missing from the shed in 2025.

CCTV footage analysed by the police showed Sulthan carrying the goat to a car near the victim’s house.

The police registered a case against Sulthan and his accomplice Thirumalai under Section 303(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita that criminalises theft with three years of imprison-

ment. An FIR copy of the case is available with *The Hindu*.

The police said that since then, the trial of the case has been under way at Judicial Magistrate-I court in Vaniyambadi town. The next hearing is slated for July 22.

Sulthan has been appointed as government pleader at the District and Sessions Court in Tirupattur.

Court officials said that as government pleader, he will appear before the court for civil cases related to government officials, including District Collector, Revenue Divisional Officer, and officials of other government departments such as Tangedco and revenue.

Legal experts said that filing of cases does not restrict individuals from assuming government positions.

‘Only a suspect’

The experts said that as per law, such positions cannot be occupied only when the individuals are convicted in the case filed against them.

“As per law, individuals cannot assume government positions only when they are convicted in a case against them. Otherwise, such individuals are only ‘suspects’.

The State government has discretionary powers to appoint such individuals who are only suspects,” said M. Balu, secretary, Vaniyambadi Bar Association.

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Tender Notice No. 2026472212275

The following e-tender is published in the IREPS website. For details about Eligibility and other Terms & Conditions, please refer IREPS website <https://www.ireps.gov.in> Manual offers will not be entertained for the tender.

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of the Work	Closing	Opening
1	2026472212275	Migration from Solid Works to NX CAD Software for ICF D&D Centre	20.07.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	20.07.2026 after 15.00 hrs.

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FOURTEENTH ANNIVERSARY

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Expired on 06.07.2012
Fondly Remembered by
SRIHARI BADRINATH

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Sl. No.	Tender No.	Name of the Work	Closing	Opening
1	2026472212247	Setting up of Disaster Recovery Solution at D & D Centre	22.07.2026 at 15.00 hrs.	22.07.2026 after 15.00 hrs.

INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY

Tender Notice No. ICF/PCMM/EOT/27/2026 Dated: 03.07.2026

The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against these tenders. Manual quotations will not be entertained for these tenders. Closing and Opening time for all tenders are 14.15 hrs. Hindi version of tender notice is available on website www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in

Sl. No.	Tender No.	Tender Title	Quantity	Due Date / Time
01	03261945	2mm Sheet SUS 301L - DLT DULL FIN	12925 Kgs	17/07/2026
02	03261803	Yaw damper, Primary Vertical Damper, Horizontal Damper and Secondary Vertical Damper for VB/TS	Refer IREPS Website	17/07/2026
03	03261662	Lower Spring Seat Complete	16926 Nos	20/07/2026
04	02261686	S & I of Body Shell ITEMS (LWLRRM)	33 Sets	20/07/2026
05	02261444	Under Frame (MEMU TC)	129 Nos	20/07/2026
06	08261587	S & I CABLE DUCT & PIPE MOUNTING LS/LWS	319 Sets	21/07/2026
07	01255138D	Supply and Installation of 15 HP Screw Type Air Compressor	2 Nos	22/07/2026
08	08261433	AWS - Automatic Warning System RDSO/ 538-7	31 Sets	22/07/2026
09	01265066A	Laser Welding Machine 3000 W	1 Nos	23/07/2026
10	01265285	Manufacture, supply and installation of Underframe fixture for VB Sleeper coach	1 Nos	23/07/2026
11	08261594	S & I Cable Duct U/F & Pipe Mounting LAC	300 Nos	23/07/2026
12	08261572	Design, Manufacture, Supply, Testing and Commissioning of the 200 Nos of 20 Car Next Generation Intercity Trains and Maintenance of Trains	200 Sets	30/09/2026

CORRIGENDUM No. 27

Corrigendum has been issued to the following tender. Please check IREPS website for further details.

Sl. No	Tender No.	Existing Value	Modified Value
01	02260053	01/07/2026	08/07/2026
02	03261849	29/06/2026	14/07/2026
03	08252751	02/07/2026	10/07/2026
04	08261549	02/07/2026	07/07/2026



Two together

India and Japan did well to ring-fence their ties from multilateral accords

Japanese Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi's first official visit to India turned out to be an occasion to signal enhanced bilateral coordination in the face of global uncertainties. Rapid changes in geopolitics and technological advances are forcing all countries into fresh thinking, most consequentially with regard to China. The U.S. appears less enthusiastic about the Quad grouping (with India, Japan and Australia) and is unsure of the nomenclature “Indo-Pacific” in its strategy. Against this backdrop, India and Japan declared a joint intent to continue with an ‘updated’ Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP) posture, ring-fencing bilateral ties from multilateral arrangements. Ms. Takaichi signed at least 16 agreements and documents, including a joint statement on energy resilience to support bilateral cooperation along the ‘maritime energy transport value chain’. The commitments to energy cooperation were supported by the awareness that to play lead roles in the FOIP, the two sides should cooperate in the energy domain from South Asia to the Indo-Pacific. This concern was also linked with the problems both sides faced regarding the safety of energy-carrying ships and sailors during the U.S.-Israel war against Iran. The two major Asian economies have a shared interest in ensuring that the nearest energy sources in the Gulf remain accessible. They have agreed to build naval platforms to enhance maritime domain awareness and surveillance.

A joint statement issued during the visit mentioned “serious concerns” about the prevailing situation in the South China and East China Seas, and Japanese officials spoke to the media frankly about the need to address the Taiwan issue peacefully. Though a planned visit to Guwahati was dropped, Ms. Takaichi underscored Japan's attention to the northeastern regions of India by connecting them with “relevant partners and regional organisations” of the Bay of Bengal region. BIMSTEC was mentioned as a partner organisation for Japan. Japan has major investments in Bangladesh and Thailand, and connecting these projects, including the Matarbari port in Cox's Bazar, through an ‘industrial value chain’ with India's northeast can boost regional prosperity and security. Ms. Takaichi has painted a vast canvas of cooperation stretching from India's neighbourhood to the Pacific Ocean to protect the India-Japan relationship from the uncertainties of the current world order, but both sides have to manage multiple other relations effectively to ensure optimal outcomes. They have to manage their relations with China and the U.S. in such a manner that their strategic interests are protected and conflicts avoided. It can be a path of mutual learning and cooperation for India and Japan as they seek to navigate the global turbulence.

Old wine, new bottle

EPFO's recent changes signal continuity, not radical reform

The Union Labour and Employment Ministry's notification of fresh rules for the Employees' Provident Fund (EPF), Employees' Pension Scheme (EPS), and Employees' Deposit Linked Insurance (EDLI) is a procedural formality following the enforcement of the Code on Social Security, 2020, since November last year. Four months ago, the Central Board of Trustees (CBT) of the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) approved the implementation of social security measures framed as a sequel to the Code that subsumes nine laws, including the Employees' State Insurance Act, 1948, and the Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952. With around eight crore subscribers, changes to the PF legal framework have wide implications for members and their families. Viewed from this angle, the notification signalled continuity and sought to make the framework align with the Code. Even the feature of PF contributions being made voluntary in excess of the statutory wage ceiling of ₹15,000 is not new. The practice of allowing contributions up to 12% of the basic pay, regardless of the wage ceiling, was the norm till the COVID-19 pandemic hit. It was only then that many establishments, while experiencing the shortage of funds, had begun limiting their contributions to the wage ceiling. However, pensioners and members had hoped that the notification would revise the minimum monthly pension of ₹1,000 and the monthly wage ceiling for contribution to the PF beyond ₹15,000, both of which were determined 12 years ago. But they have been left disappointed. According to the EPFO's 2024-25 annual report, about 36.8 lakh of its 81.5 lakh pensioners receive a monthly pension of ₹1,000 or less.

Yet, the government has taken no decision on either issue despite repeated demands from pensioners and other stakeholders. Even if financial implications are a concern, the government's grant-in-aid for the minimum pension, benefiting about 20.6 lakh pensioners, is only around ₹1,000 crore annually. Of the government's outlay of ₹11,000-odd crore towards the EPS for the current year, most of its provision goes for the component of its contribution at 1.16% of the monthly pay (limited to the wage ceiling of ₹15,000) of EPS members. The government should restore the applicability of the EPS to all workers, regardless of pay. If the government feels that the EPFO is getting overburdened with its work, it can formulate a tailored scheme with the Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority. Efforts to expedite and simplify claim settlements should continue. The government must remember that substantive EPFO decisions affect crores of employees.

On June 24, 2026, a member of India's Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) released a startling statement. The Indian passport, the person said, is a “travel document” and not a “citizenship document”. The assertion set off a minor storm. The reasonable question that followed from many was if the passport would not do it, what document would?

Posed this way, the MEA's statement and the questions it raises become something of a red herring. A passport can only be issued to a non-citizen in exceptional circumstances, where the Government of India is of the opinion that it is necessary to do so in “public interest”. Surely, therefore, barring those cases where this power is exercised, a passport must be seen as conclusive proof of a person's citizenship.

No doubt, it might be open for the government to establish under law that a person obtained the document by concealing the true status of his or her citizenship. But that does not mean a passport can be dismissed as merely a travel document.

Citizenship under scrutiny

The MEA's statement takes on an ominous heft when set against the milieu in which it was made. It arrives in the middle of the Election Commission of India (ECI)'s Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in various States. It also comes in the wake of a pair of pronouncements by the Supreme Court of India, most recently on the validity of the SIR in Bihar and the ECI's power to scrutinise citizenship, and, before that, on the Assam Accord, in which the Court had much to say on how it conceives republican ideas of citizenship. Moreover, since an amendment to the Citizenship Act in 2019 (made operational in 2024), rules of naturalisation have been rewritten along religious lines. Taken together, all these developments must prompt us to ask an elementary question: what does it mean to be a citizen of India, who belongs, and on what terms?

The Constitution's answers to these questions, even if some find them indecisive, were reached with some amount of care and caution. Part II to the document, comprising Articles 5 to 11, settled the citizenship of those caught amidst the tragedies of Partition. Article 11 reserved to Parliament a seemingly plenary power to legislate and “make any provision with respect to the acquisition and termination of citizenship and all other matters relating to citizenship”.

On a plain and literal reading, it might seem like the Union legislature was accorded unlimited authority to determine what factors can govern citizenship. Indeed, much of the contemporary defence of religiously founded citizenship laws



Suhrith Parthasarathy

Advocate practising in the Madras High Court

Paperwork cannot outweigh personhood in a constitutional democracy's citizenship framework

has rested on such an interpretation. But a careful construal of the Constituent Assembly debates, as Gautam Bhatia has shown, suggests that the framers did not treat citizenship as a matter on which Parliament could do as it pleased.

The foundations of citizenship

Consider, for example, an amendment moved to the draft provisions of the Constitution by P.S. Deshmukh. He sought to include an express stipulation “that every person who is a Hindu or a Sikh by religion and is not a citizen of any other State, wherever he resides shall be entitled to be a citizen of India”. The effort was met with sharp resistance. Among those opposing the move was Jawaharlal Nehru, who rejected the amendment outright, finding it “absurd on the face of it”.

Alladi Krishnaswami Ayyar provided the most forthright response to it. He argued that India was pledged to the principles of a secular state. Therefore, there was simply no question of making a distinction between one kind of person and another on any “racial or religious” ground. Ultimately, Deshmukh's proposal was defeated, and B.R. Ambedkar's neutral citizenship clause was affirmed.

Thus, freestanding as the words in Article 11 might be, they must be understood in the context of their wider framing. They have in them an implied limitation drawn from the Constitution's most cherished and foundational commitments to secularism, equality, and non-discrimination. Parliament can decide the modalities of citizenship, but it cannot make religion a condition for entry.

At its conception, India adopted the principle of *jus soli*, that is a form of citizenship predicated on residence and birth. The Citizenship Act, 1955, saw the principle as its primary governing creed. But over time, the legislature moved away from the theory. First, in 1985, Section 6A was introduced into the Act to give effect to the Assam Accord, suspending the conferment of citizenship based on the dates on which people of “Indian origin” had come into India. Second, in 2003, the statute was further amended to deny citizenship to persons born in India even when only one of the parents of such person was an “illegal migrant”.

In upholding Section 6A, the Supreme Court in October 2024, appeared to fortify two principles. It effectively saw no implied limitation in Article 11 and instead viewed the grant of power to Parliament to be virtually unlimited. It also appeared to lend constitutional respectability to an idea first promulgated by it in *Sarbananda Sonowal vs Union Of India & Anr.* (2005), that migration into Assam constituted “external aggression” against the State.

Hormuz to home, India's resilience in uncertain times

The Strait of Hormuz has long been recognised as one of the world's most critical maritime routes. Nearly a fifth of global oil consumption passes through this narrow waterway, making it indispensable to global energy security and international trade. Any disruption here immediately reverberates across shipping, freight, insurance and commodity markets.

As someone closely associated with the shipping industry, I witnessed this uncertainty first-hand. One of our company's vessels was among those caught amid heightened tensions in West Asia. We were confronted with an evolving security situation, uncertainty over navigation, and delays that disrupted commercial operations.

Yet, what stood out during this difficult period was the speed and coordination of the Indian government's response. Through continuous engagement with shipping companies, diplomatic channels, maritime authorities and international partners, Indian authorities ensured the safe movement of Indian-flagged vessels. That timely intervention inspired confidence at a time when uncertainty was at its peak. Equally reassuring was the government's unwavering focus on Indian crew and seafarers, ensuring that they remained protected amid one of the world's most challenging shipping environments.

This experience is just one example of India's growing ability to respond swiftly and decisively to external shocks. Whether during the COVID-19 pandemic, global supply chain disruptions, or recent geopolitical tensions in West Asia, India's institutional response has increasingly been characterised by coordination, agility, and strategic foresight.

Economic stability under pressure

India imports nearly 90% of its crude oil requirements, making it particularly vulnerable to disruptions in energy-producing regions. Rising crude prices, elevated freight costs and shipping delays could easily have translated into widespread inflationary pressures and economic uncertainty. Despite these headwinds, India's macroeconomic fundamentals have remained



Vijay Sankar

Senior Vice President, Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI) and Chairman, The Sanmar Group

A calibrated approach and coordination marked India's response to global energy shocks

remarkably resilient. Inflation has broadly remained within the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s target band despite global commodity volatility, while India continues to be the fastest-growing major economy, supported by strong domestic demand, public investment and expanding manufacturing.

What deserves particular recognition is the manner in which the government has managed the energy challenge. Unlike in several countries where consumers experienced sharp increases in fuel prices or even supply shortages, India adopted a calibrated approach aimed at protecting households while maintaining macroeconomic stability. The government relied on a combination of supply diversification, diplomatic engagement, inventory management and coordinated action with public sector energy companies to ensure uninterrupted availability of petroleum products. Retail fuel prices have been managed prudently, helping to moderate inflationary pressures.

Energy management strategy

The government's strategy has been built around a whole-of-government approach under the leadership and guidance of the Prime Minister, with Ministries, State governments, municipal authorities, oil marketing companies and industry associations working in close coordination to ensure uninterrupted supplies of oil and gas while minimising disruptions to economic activity. In the case of natural gas, the government encouraged the use of piped natural gas (PNG) wherever existing infrastructure permitted. This flexibility was made possible because of sustained investments over the past decade. India's City Gas Distribution network has expanded from just 55 geographical areas in 2014 to over 300 today.

Similarly, exporters navigating rising freight charges, insurance premiums and shipping delays received targeted support. Measures aimed at strengthening export resilience, including liquidity support, logistics facilitation and simplified customs procedures, helped businesses continue servicing international

This rationale carried into its judgment in *Association for Democratic Reforms vs Union of India*, delivered in May this year, where the Court upheld the SIR exercise in Bihar, holding that the ECI may enquire into a person's citizenship, for the “limited” purpose of deciding eligibility for the electoral roll. The Court described the distinction it drew as “principled”, between an adjudication on citizenship and on the administrative satisfaction concerning the continuation of a person's name on the electoral roll. Where the ECI is not satisfied with a person's assertion of citizenship, it ought simply to refer the case to the “competent authority” under the Citizenship Act.

But we have been down this road before. In Assam, during an earlier revision, voters marked “doubtful” were despatched to foreigners' tribunals and consigned to an endless bureaucratic maze to establish their citizenship. Today, therefore, we have ourselves a machinery in which a person need not be declared as a foreigner to be stripped of their basic rights. Instead, they are placed in a vacuum, neither confirmed nor cleared, with their rights being held in indefinite suspension.

Against this backdrop the MEA's clarification appears menacing. Running through all these exercises to establish citizenship is a common thread over the burden of proof. Where a resident could once rely on the state to take their citizenship as given, the onus today has been quietly shifted onto them. Almost any document adduced is seen as inadequate evidence. The Aadhaar card, we are told, is proof only of residence; the voter ID, only of prior registration; and now the passport, only of a right to travel.

The primacy of personhood

Under the Constitution, many of our basic privileges are premised on personhood. Article 14 guarantees equality before the law to “any person”, and Article 21 the right to life and personal liberty to all. Citizenship is built on this foundation. It allows one the freedoms guaranteed under Article 19, to speech and expression, to carry on any trade or business, and to assemble peacefully. And it is the status of citizenship that guarantees one the statutory right to vote, to choose one's lawmakers, and to decide how one ought to be governed. Therefore, to be cast out of the position is to forfeit what Hannah Arendt called the right to have rights.

In a constitutional order where personhood comes first, the rules that determine who qualifies as a citizen must rest on more than the accident of paperwork. They must be built on what the Constitution most cherishes, on the equal dignity of every person and the right of each to equal protection of the law.

markets despite disruptions to maritime trade. India's strong merchandise exports growth of 16% during April-May FY27 is a clear reflection of this.

The RBI has also complemented government efforts by maintaining financial stability. Despite elevated global uncertainty, liquidity conditions have remained comfortable, financial markets continued to function smoothly, and the banking system remained well-capitalised. The RBI's steady communication and measures such as forex swap facilities, scheme for raising foreign currency deposits from non-resident Indians as well as rationalisation of taxes on foreign portfolio investors (FPI) have been critical in strengthening India's external sector resilience.

India was among the economies most vulnerable to this crisis, yet its policy response has been among the most effective. Across the world, governments grappled with surging fuel prices, elevated inflation and supply shortages. India's strategic response has ensured preserving macroeconomic stability and maintaining growth momentum.

India's preparedness

No economy today can completely insulate itself from geopolitical uncertainty. Commodity markets react instantly to conflict, shipping disruptions ripple across continents and supply chains remain deeply interconnected. A key learning from the Hormuz episode is that resilience is no longer built through emergency response alone. It is created through years of investment in infrastructure, diversified supply chains, institutional coordination and policy preparedness.

Over the past decade, India has steadily expanded refining capacity, diversified crude sourcing, strengthened strategic petroleum reserves, built gas infrastructure, modernised logistics networks and accelerated the transition toward cleaner energy. These investments become invaluable when external shocks test the economy. As India advances towards its vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047, it is institutional capability that will become an increasingly important competitive advantage.

at the slightest provocation, filed defamation cases against her political rivals.

reminds one of the style of functioning of former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa, who,

of DMK MLA Anitha Radhakrishnan, one expects Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay to show a more tolerance than his predecessors towards his political opponents. Even if the remarks were not in good taste, free speech is paramount in a mature democracy. The arrest

funding raises suspicion, while modern-day gurus speak of spirituality but appear to embrace crass materialism, sending the wrong message to society. **V. Nagarajan,** Chennai

Free speech
In the context of the arrest

Material concerns
Today, many temples receive large donations, making their proper management more important than ever. But the problem goes far beyond temples, as corruption continues to thrive in the political ecosystem. Large election

Corrections & Clarifications

The fifth paragraph of an article, “Inside India's language conundrum” (‘Ground Zero’ page, July 4, 2026), referred to English “being one of the 22 official languages in the Eight Schedule of the Constitution”. While English is an official language of the Union under the constitutional provisions relating to official languages, it is not included in the Eighth Schedule.

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The top court had to step in. It would have been more gracious had Mr. Vijay expressed his disapproval to the leader of the Opposition. **N.G.R. Prasad,** Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

India needs a second home for Asiatic lions

India’s conservation of the Asiatic lion is widely celebrated as a remarkable success story. From a population which was reduced to just a few dozen in the early 20th century, the number of Asiatic lions has increased to approx. 891 today. Yet, behind this achievement lies a persistent policy failure: the inability to establish a second, geographically separate population. Scientific institutions, government bodies, and even the Supreme Court have long warned that without such a step, the species remains vulnerable to extinction from a single catastrophic event.

A second dwelling
The need for a second home for Asiatic lions is rooted in decades of government-backed research. Multiple reports of the Wildlife Institute of India have consistently emphasised that a single population confined to one landscape is inherently vulnerable. Studies conducted since the 1980s have concluded that threats such as epidemics, forest fires, or other natural disasters could potentially wipe out the entire species if it remains geographically concentrated.

This scientific consensus was formally acknowledged in the landmark Supreme Court judgment of April 15, 2013, which directed the translocation of Asiatic lions from Gujarat’s Gir forest to the Kuno National Park in Madhya Pradesh. The Court made it clear that conservation must be guided by ecological principles rather than regional considerations, stating that a second population was essential for the species’ long-term survival. The judgment explicitly recognised the risk that a single calamity could eliminate the entire population if it remained confined to one location.

Despite this clear directive, the translocation project has been stalled for over a decade. Gujarat has consistently resisted the relocation of lions outside the



Richa Singh
Senior Consultant at EY India, with a focus on forest management, wildlife conservation and biodiversity assessment

Reports by the Wildlife Institute of India have consistently emphasised that a single population confined to one landscape is inherently vulnerable



An Asiatic lioness with her two cubs at the Sakkarbaugh Safari breeding centre in Junagadh in 2025. VIJAY SONEJI

State, citing its success in conserving the species and raising concerns about habitat suitability elsewhere. This has created a policy impasse between scientific recommendations, judicial mandates, and State-level political considerations. While the Kuno National Park was prepared specifically to host the lions – by relocation of villages and habitat restoration among others – no lions have been introduced there.

Meanwhile, the ecological risks identified by experts have only intensified. The concentration of the entire global population of Asiatic lions within the Gir landscape makes them uniquely vulnerable to disease outbreaks. The 2018 outbreak of the Canine Distemper Virus among the population, which killed several lions and infected many others, serves as a stark reminder of this danger. Such diseases spread more rapidly in dense, socially structured populations, and their impact is amplified by the limited genetic diversity of the lions.

Government-supported studies and conservation plans have repeatedly highlighted that geographically isolated carnivore populations face extinction risks from both biological and environmental factors. In a single-site population, even non-recurring events – such as droughts, wildfires, or sudden prey decline – can have disproportionate effects. This is why conservation science advocates for a “metapopulation

approach”, where species are distributed across multiple habitats to reduce risk.

Recognising these concerns, recent policy initiatives such as Project Lion (2020) have attempted to revive the discussion on expanding lion habitats. There have been proposals to develop alternative sites such as the Barda Wildlife Sanctuary within Gujarat itself. However, experts argue that such sites, being geographically close to Gir, may not adequately address the core issue of risk diversification. A second population must be sufficiently distant to prevent the spread of disease or disaster across both populations simultaneously.

The delay in establishing a second home raises broader questions about environmental governance in India. It reflects a tension between national conservation priorities and State-level interests, where wildlife – though constitutionally recognised as a shared responsibility – can become entangled in regional identity and political considerations. The Supreme Court had clearly stated that Asiatic lions are a national heritage, not the property of any single State, yet implementation of this principle remains incomplete.

From success to security
Ultimately, the issue is whether India is willing to move from conservation success to conservation security. The current situation represents a paradox: a thriving population that remains ecologically fragile. Without establishing a second free-ranging population, the gains of decades of conservation effort remain vulnerable to reversal. The case of the Asiatic lion underscores a fundamental principle of modern conservation: numbers alone do not ensure survival; resilience does. Creating a second home is an ecological necessity; continued delay in implementing this vision risks turning a global conservation triumph into a preventable ecological vulnerability.

A legislative tangle in Maharashtra

The grey areas in the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution needs urgent revisiting

STATE OF PLAY

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit



The legislative tangle behind the political switches in Maharashtra raises questions about the grey areas in the Tenth Schedule of the Constitution. On June 30, Sachin Ahir, a Shiv Sena UBT (Uddhav Balasaheb Thackeray) leader, switched allegiance from Mr. Thackeray to Eknath Shinde’s Shiv Sena. The very next day, he was unanimously elected as the Deputy Chairperson of the Maharashtra Legislative Council. He claimed that he had not switched parties, and that he was voted to power as an MLC (Member of the Legislative Council) in 2022 as a Shiv Sena leader. The vertical split in the party happened after he became the MLC, and therefore, on paper, Mr. Ahir has continued to be a Shiv Sena MLC.

This event seemed like a replay of an incident which happened in Maharashtra two years ago. On July 7, 2023, Neelam Gorhe, another senior Shiv Sena UBT leader and the then Deputy Chairperson of the Maharashtra Legislative Council, had similarly switched from the UBT group to Mr. Shinde’s Shiv Sena. She too claimed that she was elected as a Shiv Sena leader in 2020 and that she had not changed parties.

In 2022, the Shiv Sena faced an internal rebellion wherein Mr. Shinde pitted himself against Mr. Thackeray and claimed to be the leader of the original party. While the Election Commission has handed over the original party name and symbol to Mr. Shinde, the matter is still sub-judice in the Supreme Court.

Two years ago, Mr. Thackeray’ party had sought Ms.

Gorhe’s disqualification as an MLC. Currently, it is mulling on the possibility of legal action against Mr. Ahir.

Mr. Ahir’s is not the only switch which drew political attention in the last few weeks in Maharashtra. Six of the nine Lok Sabha MPs of the UBT group also moved over to Mr. Shinde’s Shiv Sena last month.

Consequences of defection
All these switches have led to discussions about whether these legislators can be disqualified. The Tenth Schedule of the Constitution deals with the provisions of the disqualification of legislators.

At the heart of Mr. Ahir’s change in loyalty is Paragraph 5 of the Tenth Schedule.

Paragraph 5 gives the grounds for exemption from disqualification. It says that the Speaker or the Deputy Speaker or the Chairperson or the Deputy Chairperson shall not be disqualified if “he, by reason of his election to such office, voluntarily gives up the membership of the political party to which he belonged immediately before such election and does not, so long as he continues to hold such office thereafter, rejoin that political party or become a member of another political party.” Mr. Ahir filed his nomination papers for the Deputy Chairperson of the Maharashtra Legislative Council in the presence of the Chief Minister and two Deputy Chief Minis-

ters. He was elected unopposed to the position just 24 hours after changing loyalties. However, importantly, both Mr. Ahir as well as the Shiv Sena have claimed that the legislative records show Mr. Ahir as Shiv Sena MLC, and not as a Shiv Sena-UBT MLC. Therefore, the question of disqualification does not arise.

But legal experts say that the exemption is applicable only if the Deputy Chairperson wants to discontinue ties with the party he belonged to. He cannot claim allegiance to another party. In this case, Mr. Ahir’s legislative conduct for the last four years, from 2022 to 2026, shows his allegiance to Mr. Thackeray.

It will also need to be verified if Mr. Ahir had submitted an affidavit to the Election Commission supporting Mr. Thackeray during the legal battle for the name and symbol of the party.

The other contention is about the defection of the six Lok Sabha MPs. Paragraph 4 of the Tenth Schedule pertains to how disqualification on the grounds of defection does not apply in the case of a merger. It states that a member of a House shall not be disqualified “where his original party merges with another political party.” Legal experts point towards the Supreme Court observations in the *Subhash Desai* case about the ‘umbilical cord between the original political party and the legislature party’. In this case, they say, it has been overlooked.

While discussions about the political implications of these defections have taken centre-stage, experts say there is an urgent need to address the grey areas in the 10th Schedule on a priority basis.

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Questioning the hype around U.P.’s ‘revenue surplus’

Data shows that the so-called surplus stems from the State’s persistent inability to spend its own budget

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A.

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, who spoke about the State’s growth at his government’s Industry Leaders Roadshow in Bengaluru on June 24, emphasised how U.P. has had a “revenue surplus in the last six years”. The Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG)’s 2024-25 State Finances Report released on June 16 said that U.P. not only reported revenue surpluses in 2024-25, but its ₹59,327 crore surplus was the highest, accounting for nearly 50% of the total revenue surplus of ₹1.27 lakh crore reported by 13 States.

Yet an analysis of CAG and RBI data shows that this surplus stems from U.P.’s persistent inability to spend its own budget. Over the past decade, it has consistently underspent its budgeted expenditure, by at least 15% every year since 2019-20 (**Chart 1**).

A revenue surplus is merely the gap between total receipts and revenue expenditure. In 2024-25, U.P.’s revenue realisation fell about 16% short of budget; yet it still reported a surplus because its revenue expenditure fell short by a larger 15.4%. Maharashtra, by contrast, nearly met its revenue targets and spent more than budgeted, thereby reporting a deficit (**Chart 2**). Had U.P. spent at the efficiency of Maharashtra, its surplus would have shrunk sharply or turned into deficits (**Chart 3**).

In 2024-25, U.P. spent only ₹1.13 lakh crore of its ₹1.55 lakh crore capital outlay, which is a gap of 27%, suggesting that the underspending is systemic rather than mere caution towards controlling revenue expenditure (**Chart 4**). U.P.’s revenue surplus is contributed in no small measure by Central transfers (**Chart 5**). Yet, U.P. underspends even the funds budgeted by the Centre, despite receiving the highest allocation.

Prudence or inefficiency?

The data for the charts and the analysis were sourced from the States Finances reports of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India and the Reserve Bank of India. The statements of Finance and Appropriation accounts of State governments submitted to the CAG were also used

CHART 1: This shows the deviation from the total budgeted expenditure of 10 States with the biggest economies in terms of Gross State Domestic Product

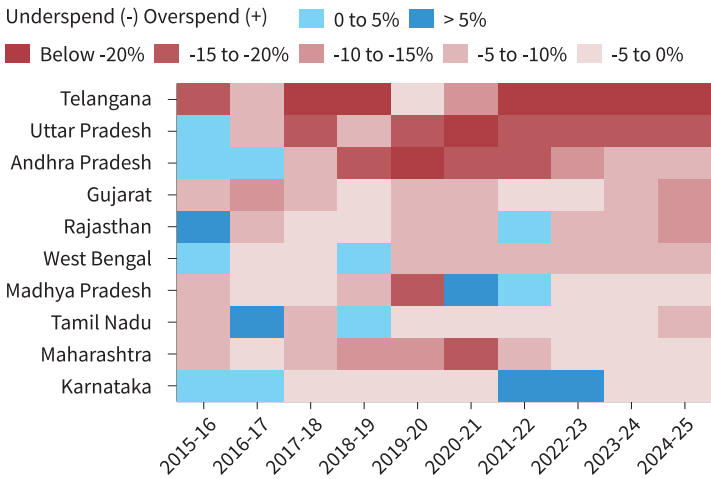


CHART 3: This shows different outcomes of U.P.’s revenue surplus status had it spent as budgeted or on par with its peers

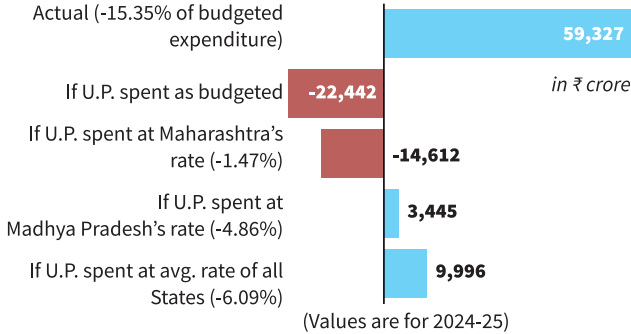


CHART 4: U.P.’s underspending pattern was worse with capital expenditure, as shown below

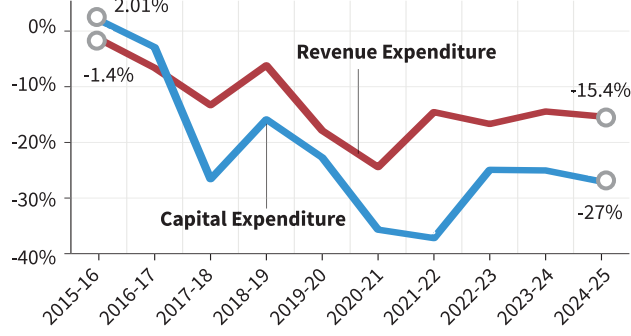


CHART 2: This shows how U.P.’s revenue surplus is mainly due to its underspending by contrasting its budgeting and expenditure patterns with Maharashtra

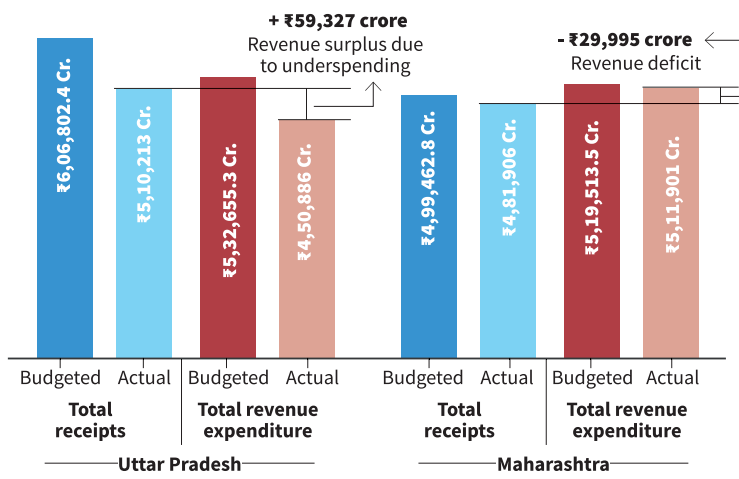


CHART 5: This shows the share of Central transfers in the total revenue of States with 10 biggest economies

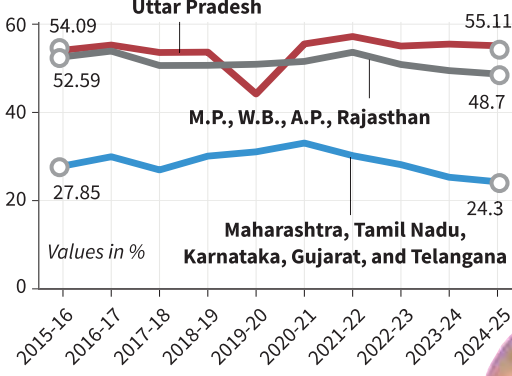
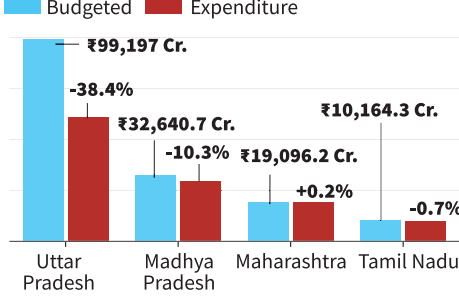


CHART 6: This shows the Govt’s budgeted share towards central schemes and percentage of underspending



NOTE: The 44.2% drop of U.P. in 2019-20 was due to the State making a one-time “book transfer” of ₹71,180 crore from its Sinking Fund, a reserve fund maintained for repaying debts, to the State’s non-tax revenue receipts. CAG was critical of this in its audit report for that year. Had this transfer not happened, the share of Central transfers for the year would have been 54.8%.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO JULY 6, 1976

Ford asks Americans to preserve peace

Philadelphia (Pennsylvania), July 5: President Gerald Ford marked the 200th birthday of the United States yesterday by telling more than 1,00,000 cheering people that peace and justice throughout the world would depend in large measure on the way Americans preserved peace and justice in their own country during its third century.

President Ford was speaking at Independence Hall in Philadelphia where representatives from 13 American colonies proclaimed their rejection of British rule by signing the Declaration of Independence on July 4, 1776.

Earlier, Mr. Ford visited Valley Forge, where George Washington’s army endured terrible hardship during the winter of 1777. The President chose the occasion to warn Americans that no great power could survive unless it cherished force of character and courage.

The Americans must not give themselves over to the pleasures of easy living and prosperity Mr. Ford declared. More than 50,000 persons gathered at the historic camp site for the bicentennial celebrations.

Covered wagons from the States that formed the 13 colonies and from other regions gathered at Valley Forge for the celebration. Mr. Ford mounted a wagon from Michigan, his home State, together with his daughter, Susan.

Later, the President reviewed an armada of sailing ships on the Hudson River, where warships from more than 50 nations assembled to salute the bicentennial.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JULY 6, 1926

Torrential rains at Bombay

Bombay, July 5: During the last two days, Bombay has been receiving a heavy downpour of rain accompanied by high wind registering nearly 8 inches, since Saturday early morning. It rained torrentially, from Sunday afternoon till midday on Monday.

The streets were flooded, dislocating tramcar and other vehicular traffic. The heavy rain did great damage to the underground telephone cables, cutting off some of the brigade stations. The greater part of the city had to put up with partial absence of telephone service.

The railway lines were submerged but that did not interfere with local train service.

INBRIEF



Kaziranga bids adieu to iconic patrol elephant Joymala

Officials and guards of the Kaziranga National Park and Tiger Reserve in Assam on Sunday bid an emotional farewell to Joymala, one of the longest-serving elephants of the one-horned rhino habitat. Officials said Joymala, inducted as a “jungle warrior” in 1992, died on Saturday. She was 66. Joymala earned international recognition in 2004 when a stray tiger leapt over her while she was on patrol. The dramatic incident, captured on camera, became one of Kaziranga’s most iconic wildlife images, drawing global attention to the courage and composure of the park’s patrol elephants and their handlers. Joymala’s last rites were performed with a guard of honour by Kaziranga’s Forest personnel.

Bengal CM announces ₹313 cr. for tea workers’ scheme

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Sunday said the State Government had decided to implement the *Pradhan Mantri Cha Shramik Protsahan Yojana* (PMCSPY) and announced an allocation of ₹313.30 crore for the scheme. Finance Minister Swapan Dasgupta said the West Bengal government would implement the scheme in collaboration with the Government of India, and the focus would be on improving the living standards of tea garden workers and their families. The Central scheme, with a total outlay of ₹1,000 crore, aims to provide more than 10 lakh workers across 1,210 tea gardens in Assam and West Bengal access to better facilities.

India to host BRICS anti-drugs meet today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India will host the two-day BRICS Heads of Anti-Drug Agencies meeting in Guwahati from Monday.

Organised by the Narcotics Control Bureau, the meeting will focus on issues such as combating synthetic drugs, strengthening intelligence sharing and operational coordination, and capacity building and institutional cooperation.

“India envisions this meeting as a pivotal step in transforming BRICS cooperation from dialogue-centric engagement to structured and action-oriented collaboration, with a focus on strengthening operational coordination, intelligence sharing, capacity building, and collective responses to emerging drug-related threats,” the Union Home Ministry said in a statement.

“As chair, New Delhi will seek to strengthen cooperation through information sharing on clandestine laboratories and emerging synthetic drug trends, enhanced monitoring of precursor chemicals and pharmaceuticals, intelligence exchange, sharing of best practices, joint training programmes and expert exchanges,” it said.

ISRO conducts test of key component for Gaganyaan mission

The solid motor-based platform SOLVE will be used for parachute tests of the crew module; it has been derived from the PSLV strap-on motor

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) has successfully carried out the first ground test of the solid motor-based Sub-Orbital Launch Vehicle for Experiments (SOLVE) at its Static Test Facility at the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota.

The SOLVE solid motor is a key component for conducting Gaganyaan test missions and the first ground test was carried out on July 3.

The ISRO is developing a solid motor-based SOLVE as a test platform to carry out Integrated Parachute Tests for validation of deceleration system of Gaganyaan’s crew module under various test conditions.

During these test missions, the crew module will be carried to an altitude of 10 km to 17 km and separated from the vehicle.

A series of 10 parachutes will be deployed to reduce the velocity of the crew module before splashdown in the sea.



The ground test of the SOLVE solid motor being conducted at the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The solid stage of SOLVE is derived from the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV) Strap-on Motor with a few modifications to meet the Gaganyaan test requirements, including development of slow burn rate propellant and straight nozzle with secondary injection thrust vector control.

The ISRO said that during the test motor performance parameters were as expected. “The development of the SOLVE vehicle provides flexibility in conducting Gaganyaan test missions simulating various conditions in the actual mission,” the space agency said.

Over the past few months, the ISRO has carried out key tests related to the Gaganyaan mission, which include the second Integrated Air Drop Test (IADT-02) and a behavioural study Mission MITRA (Mapping of Interoperable Traits and Response Assessment) in Leh, during which the four Indian astronauts selected for the mission along with scientists, engineers and medical teams were subjected to a week-long study.

Over the past few months, the ISRO has carried out key tests related to the Gaganyaan mission, which include the second Integrated Air Drop Test (IADT-02) and a behavioural study Mission MITRA (Mapping of Interoperable Traits and Response Assessment) in Leh, during which the four Indian astronauts selected for the mission along with scientists, engineers and medical teams were subjected to a week-long study.

Chhattisgarh’s Pandavani legend Teejan Bai dies at 70

Shubhomov Sikdar
RAIPUR



Teejan Bai

Teejan Bai, an artist who took the ancient Chhattisgarhi folk tradition of Pandavani, the musical narration of the Mahabharata, to the world, died at 70 at the All India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS) in Raipur on Sunday after a prolonged illness.

Teejan Bai shattered stereotypes by taking up an art form traditionally performed by men, and performed with her lively voice throughout India and across the globe for decades. She was conferred the Padma Shri, Padma Bhushan, and Padma Vibhushan, India’s second-highest civilian honour.

The legendary singer had been keeping unwell for some time, and was undergoing treatment at the AIIMS, Raipur, from May 27, 2026. She died at about

3.15 a.m., doctors at the hospital confirmed. Teejan Bai was given the final farewell with full state honours at her native village, Ganiyari, later on Sunday.

Breaking barriers

Back when she started, women traditionally performed Pandavani while sitting in the Vedamati style.

However, Teejan Bai challenged this tradition and began performing standing in the Kapalika

style of male performers, with acting, dialogues, singing, and expressions. This style later became her distinctive identity. Clad in a red saree draped in the Chhattisgarhi pattern, and holding the *tanpura* (stringed instrument), she would leave audiences spellbound wherever she performed.

She brought Chhattisgarh’s folk culture to the world by performing Pandavani in more than 17 countries. Her powerful voice, acting, and storytelling style introduced Indian folk traditions to foreign audiences.

President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah, and Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai were among those who condoled Teejan Bai’s death and paid their tributes to her.

Flow of unregistered pilgrims leaves Amarnath Shrine Board worried

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

A record upward trend of pilgrims paying obeisance was registered on Sunday at the Amarnath cave shrine in Kashmir. However, the Shri Amarnath Shrine Board (SASB) is worried about the inflow of unregistered pilgrims posing a security as well as infrastructure challenge.

A total of 32,313 devotees performed pilgrimage at the cave shrine located at an altitude of 12,756 feet. A record number of 20,145 pilgrims joined the numbers on the second day of the yatra – the highest number recorded in the past several years. Over 8,000 left Jammu on Sunday for Kashmir to join pilgrims already stationed at the twin base camps of Baltal and Nunwan, official data suggested.



The SASB has put a cap on the number of pilgrims who could visit the shrine in a day, which is 10,000 for each route. IMRAN NISSAR

The Board, however, is worried by unregistered pilgrims. Most pilgrims are turning up without mandatory health checks, which determine if a pilgrim is fit to trek at high altitude.

“We are seeing a large influx of unregistered pilgrims. I strongly urge those without prior registration to remain patient and wait for their turn. This cooper-

ation is essential for a smooth and seamless yatra experience,” said J&K Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha, who is also the chairman of the Board.

Compared with the past four years, there has been a massive surge in pilgrim numbers this year, he said. “In response, the Board, and all key stakeholders have stepped up, imple-

Govt. cautions against accounts claiming foreign policy links

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The External Affairs Ministry on Sunday issued a public advisory cautioning people against making payments to certain social media handles that advertise themselves as “foreign policy” and “public policy” experts and seek money from followers on Instagram.

Official sources said a substantial number of Instagram handles claim to be active in the so-called “public policy domain”, adding that many such claims are “fraudulent”.

“It has come to the notice of the Ministry that certain individuals on social media platforms are making posts suggesting that they are advising MEA on policy related matters including on trade, migration and other issues. Further these handles are also offering paid advice/sessions on how to work with MEA,” it said.

Social media trend

An official familiar with the matter said the Ministry was prompted to issue the advisory after observing a trend in which individuals got themselves photographed at public events with External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar or senior

officials and foreign Ambassadors during public engagements, and then used those photographs to generate “likes” and seek payments by claiming they could get work done in the Ministry. “These individuals have no connection to the Ministry and the Ministry urges all to be careful against such fraudulent posts,” it said.

Officials studying the proliferation of Instagram handles said the clarification was issued after it was noticed that some individuals were making money by claiming they could get work done in the Ministry. An official said that “just in case of the cyberscam centres in Myanmar that drew government’s attention once they started targeting common citizens, in the similar manner, certain social media accounts have attracted attention as they were asking for payments from social media followers on diplomacy or MEA-related issues and therefore the issue had to be flagged”.

The Hindu has learnt that the announcement was made without naming any social media handle, but that the individuals carrying out financial activities in the name of the External Affairs Ministry have been identified.

Film on Punjab taken down 2 days after release

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Satluj, a film starring Diljit Dosanjh, has been removed from ZEE5 two days after it was released on the streaming platform. Directed by Honey Trehan, the film was earlier titled ‘*Punjab 95*’ and faced a long battle with the Central Board of Film Certification.

“We believe powerful storytelling has the ability to inspire, endure and leave a lasting impact. We remain committed to championing authentic and meaningful narratives,” the streamer said.

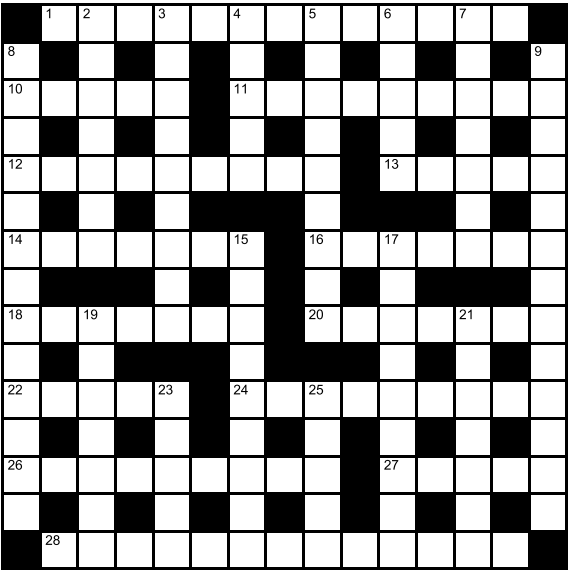
It did not disclose the exact reason for the removal. The film traces the journey of human rights activist Jaswant Singh Khrala, who exposed extra-judicial killings in Punjab during the militancy era.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14838

(set by Arden)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY

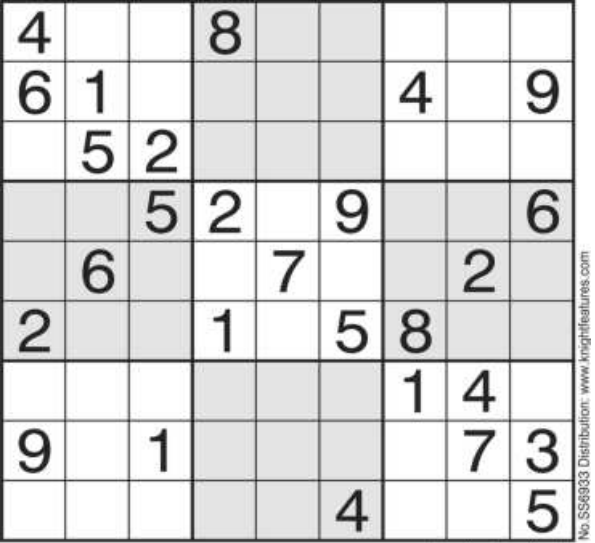


ACROSS

- 1. PM comes to grip with a druggie without work and his method of working (5,8)
- 10. Slammed as the little devil played a role (5)
- 11. With home study make true agreement (9)
- 12. Rage about one going underwater — it’s highly corrosive (4,5)

- 13. Sweep opening, take time off for golf (5)
- 14. The German drink will subside (3,4)
- 16. Good natured, is nice to back some one in the group (7)
- 18. Next to undress — questions follow revelations (7)
- 20. Lizard losing head in company of a furry animal (7)
- 22. Gets rid of bags filled with cork finally (5)
- 24. Sailing, generally (2,3,4)
- 26. Initially, no objection certificate to use radio not allowed late in the night (9)
- 27. Speak for zero value (5)
- 28. I get a front man out breaking (13)
- DOWN
- 2. Starts offering basic training — it’s impolite to interfere (7)
- 3. Experiences of active end user taking leave (9)
- 4. Start off planting being in debt (5)
- 5. Adorable, getting attention in conclusion (9)
- 6. Covered new roof within a day (5)
- 7. Pounded back of head and massaged (7)
- 8. Usually no odd ones while dealing with a dip, say (5,8)
- 9. Not even greying beard can be contrary to a radiation detector (6,7)
- 15. New subject, without ignorance (9)
- 17. “Room for suspicion”, they say, when disoriented (6-3)
- 19. Spectacular shot, showing no lust for a safety vehicle on track (4,3)
- 21. A bash over regular fashion makes one brave (7)
- 23. Suspended second breather (5)
- 25. Washroom — not one available for renting (2,3)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku

FAITH

Murugan to the rescue

Lord Murugan appeared in the dream of Kachiappa Sivachariar and asked him to write Kanda Puranam. Every day Sivachariar placed the verses he had composed that day at the feet of Lord Murugan in the Kumara Kottam temple in Kanchipuram. Murugan corrected the verses. So, Kanda Puranam had Murugan’s approval, said Sumathi Sri in a discourse. In those days, it was the norm for every new work to be placed before an assembly of scholars, and would become an acceptable part of Tamil literature, only if it was approved by the scholars. The scholars would check the work for its meaningfulness, for its rhyme and meter and its grammatical correctness. Sivachariar too placed his Kanda Puranam before the scholars. But they objected to the very first verse, saying it was grammatically incorrect. The first two verses of Kanda Puranam are in praise of Vikata Chakkara Vinayaka of Kanchipuram. The work had been checked by Lord Murugan Himself, but this was not enough for the scholars. They rejected it because in the first verse itself they detected an error. Sivachariar appealed to Lord Murugan, who said He would take care of the problem.

The next day when the scholars met again, a young man said Sivachariar’s usage was correct. He cited the rules given in a rare Tamil grammar work called *Veera-chozhiyam*. The scholars were convinced, but the young man disappeared. Sivachariar realised that Murugan Himself had come to the gathering to recommend Sivachariar’s work as praiseworthy. Murugan always comes to the rescue when His devotees are in trouble. We see this in the case of Sivachariar.

ASKUS

Vaishali R. Venkat

I wish to invest in mutual funds through SIP. However, I am confused by the various schemes and plans available, such as direct versus regular plans, open- and closed-end funds, and IDCW options. Could you provide a comprehensive overview of the different schemes and plans and the available payout options?

PAUL

An open-ended mutual fund is like a metro smart card. You can enter anytime, exit anytime and reload whenever you want. There's no fixed "start or end date," and you transact (buy/sell units) at the current NAV. Most SIP investors prefer open-ended funds for flexibility and ease of access. Remember that you need to pay an exit load, which is a small fee charged if you withdraw your money before the stipulated time (one year in most cases). Think of it like a "penalty for early exit" meant to discourage short-term trading. Once the exit load period is over, you can exit freely with no charge.

ELSS fund

Equity Linked Savings Schemes (ELSS), also open-ended in structure, come with a mandatory three-year lock-in period for claiming tax benefits. During this period, you cannot redeem or exit from your investment.

After three years, it behaves like a normal open-ended equity fund with full liquidity.

Closed-ended fund

On the other hand, a closed-ended mutual fund works similar to an IPO for stocks. It is launched through a New Fund Offer (NFO), which is usually announced via advertisements or other avenues for a limited period only. You can invest only during this offer period, just like applying for an IPO.

Subsequently, the fund is closed for new investments from the AMC side. Note, most apps or direct AMC websites offer open-ended SIPs mostly.

Direct vs. regular plans

Now, let's understand the difference between "direct vs regular" plans. Imagine buying the same product in two different ways: directly from the manufacturer or through a local shop-keeper. The product is exactly the same in both cases, but the price structure differs. Similarly, in mutual funds, a direct plan means you invest directly with the Asset Management Company (AMC), while a regular plan involves investing through an Association of Mutual Funds in India-registered (AMFI) mutual fund distributors. These brokers must have an ARN number to legally sell mutual funds.

In regular plans, the intermediary earns a commission that is built into the fund's expense ratio, which is usually higher than direct plans.

This slightly reduces your overall returns compared with direct plans, wherein there is no middle layer and therefore lower costs. As a result, a larger portion of your money remains invested and continues to grow. Therefore, most self-managed SIP investors choose direct plans, which are generally better for retail investors due to its lower expense ratio.

IDCW option

IDCW stands for Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal. In April 2021, SEBI renamed the 'Dividend Option' in mutual funds to IDCW to better describe how the payouts work. If you previously invested in a mutual fund under the Dividend Plan, you will now see IDCW in your account statements instead.

IDCW payments may be made from the income earned by the mutual fund, such as dividends received from stocks or capital gains from selling investments. That is, the payouts can come from the fund's profits or by returning a part of your invested capital, thereby reducing the fund's Net Asset Value (NAV).

Put simply, IDCW is not extra income or a bonus, but a portion of your investment being returned to you. Investors seeking long-term wealth creation should generally choose the Growth option. Those who need regular payouts from their investments may consider the IDCW option.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM's Research Analyst module)



ILLUSTRATION-SAAI

What new NPS withdrawal rules mean for retirement

With new norms, the National Pension Scheme finally treats retirement money the way most actually need it treated — accessible sans being reckless and flexible sans being chaotic

NEW TEMPLATE

Joydeep Sen

For years, the one persistent complaint about the National Pension System (NPS) was its rigidity at exit. You built a retirement corpus over 20-30 years and at 60, the rule-book decided you couldn't simply walk away with it. A large chunk had to go into an annuity. That has now changed. Let us understand what's on the table.

What changed

In December 2025, PFRDA substantially amended NPS exit/withdrawal norms. The mandatory annuity portion has come down from 40% to 20% of corpus viz subscribers can withdraw up to 80% as lump sum against 60% earlier. For smaller corpus, the rules are more generous. If accumulated NPS wealth is up to ₹8 lakh, you can withdraw the entire amount as lump sum. For ₹8-12 lakh, you can take out up to ₹6 lakh with the balance routed into structured withdrawal or annuity. Above ₹12 lakh, the 80:20 split applies.

However, there's a tax issue here. Section 10(12A) of the Income Tax Act exempts only 60% of withdrawn corpus. The additional 20% PFRDA permits you to withdraw, gets taxed at a slab rate unless the tax law catches up with the new pension norms. So, the extra liquidity is real, but plan for tax bill on

The mandatory annuity portion has reduced from 40% to 20% of corpus viz subscribers can withdraw up to 80% as lump sum against 60% earlier

the incremental 20% rather than assuming it's tax-free

Retirement planning

The practical upshot is, NPS now gives you more control on the day you stop earning salary. Earlier, a large slice of money was locked into an annuity that paid a modest return, with limited say in how it was structured. Now, you can keep much bigger share of corpus working for you in instruments and at a pace you choose. That's particularly useful if you already have other income sources at retirement or want to deploy a chunk into something more efficient, like paying off a loan.

The flip side is this freedom shifts the responsibility for managing market and longevity risk back on to you. The new system trusts you to manage a larger pool of money sensibly over a 20-25-year retirement. It needs more care.

RIS, variants

This is where PFRDA's newer reform comes in - the Retirement Income Scheme or RIS. Until recently, if you didn't want to take lump sum at once, the

The combination of a higher lump sum limit, slab-based withdrawal for smaller corpus and RIS as built-in drawdown mechanism gives mass investors real choice

main alternative was to defer withdrawal and take it out once a year which wasn't particularly useful for someone who needs monthly income to live on.

RIS addresses that gap. It applies to the non-annuity portion of corpus and lets you draw it down gradually instead of taking it in one shot while the balance stays invested and continues to earn market-linked returns. Within RIS, you choose between two payout methods. One is Systematic Lump Sum Withdrawal or SLW, where you withdraw a fixed amount at a chosen frequency - monthly, quarterly, half-yearly or annually - until age 75 (now 85 in some cases). So it will run until the corpus runs out. The other is Systematic Unit Redemption or SUR where you redeem a set number of units at each interval so the payout itself varies with the prevailing NAV. Either way money stays within NPS, continues compounding and pays on schedule you set.

MF SWP

RIS is structurally very close to a Systematic Withdrawal Plan of mutual fund

(MF). In both cases, you leave money invested and withdraw defined amount periodically rather than redeeming all at once.

A MF SWP gives wider choice of schemes and you can switch funds/change withdrawal amount with no curbs on moving money. RIS is more limited in fund choice and governed by PFRDA's process and timelines which means somewhat less flexibility.

NPS has historically run at a fraction of the cost MFs charge so the expense drag on retirement corpus is lower under RIS. MF SWP withdrawals are taxed as capital gains while RIS withdrawals sit within NPS tax framework where 60% is exempt and rest is taxed.

Neither is really better. If cost efficiency and staying in a regulated pension structure matter more, RIS fits. For wider choice of underlying funds and ability to move quickly between them, MF SWPs give that.

For the average subscriber, NPS treats retirement money the way most actually need it treated - accessible sans being reckless and flexible sans being chaotic. The combination of higher lump sum limit, slab-based withdrawal for smaller corpus and RIS as a built-in drawdown mechanism gives mass investors real choices at 60. The main thing to observe is discipline: more access to money is useful if you don't withdraw faster than retirement actually needs.

(Joydeep Sen is a corporate trainer (financial markets) and author)

Gold,silver hammered

PRECIOUSMETALS

The trend both gold and silver turned negative post the breach of key support levels; The trend for precious metals would remain weak until the resistance level is not taken out

B. Krishnakumar

Precious metals took a pounding in June with Comex gold facing the worst quarterly loss in 13-years. The hawkish stance adopted by the U.S. Federal Reserve and the firming up of the U.S. Dollar robbed the sheen off precious metals. The uncertainty surrounding the U.S.-Iran war also played a role in shaping sentiment towards the metals.

As a result, Comex gold closed almost 12% lower to settle at \$4,021.8 by the end of June. Comex gold price saw a 14.4% fall in April-June quarter. Comex silver too took a hit.

The white metal took a steeper cut of 21.88% to close at \$59.04. Silver lost as much as 21.6% in price second quarter of 2026.

Mirroring global market trend, precious metal prices took a hit in local markets too. MCX gold slid 11.49% to settle at ₹1,42,546/10-gram. MCX silver, too, closed on a weak note at ₹2,28,665/kg or a 16.58% fall.

The fall has damaged the bullish price structure in Comex gold. The breach of the lower end of the trading range of \$4,400 indicates that the short-term trend has turned negative. The short-term outlook is bleak with likely drop to \$3,750-\$3,850 range.

Negative trend

The short to medium term trend for Comex gold has turned negative now. The trend will stay weak unless the price closes above \$4,410. Until this breakout happens, expect gold price to drift lower to a target zone of \$3,750-\$3,850. The trend in Comex silver, too, has turned weak owing to the breach of the crucial support level at \$71. As a result, the price is now vulnerable to a slide to the next support zone at \$54-\$56. This view would be invalidated only if the price moves above the resistance at \$72.

The fall below lower end of prior trading range of ₹1,53,000-₹1,55,000 is a sign of weakness for MCX Gold. The price is likely to seek lower levels of ₹1,35,000-₹1,40,000 range in the near term. This view would stay valid until the price trades below ₹1,66,000.

Similar to gold, the trend in MCX silver price, too, has turned bearish as the price breached the prior support level at ₹2,80,000. The price could now drop to the next support level at ₹1,95,000-₹2,05,000 in the near term. Only a breakout above ₹2,80,000 would invalidate this negative view.

Conclusion

To summarise, the trend gold and silver turned negative post the breach of key support levels. The trend would remain weak until the resistance level mentioned above is not taken out.

(The author is a Chennai based analyst / trader. The views and opinion featured in this column is based on the analysis of short-term price movement in gold and silver futures at COMEX & Multi Commodity Exchange of India. This is not meant to be a trading or investment advice.)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Flat Rs. 99
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda *	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	8.95 onwards	10,367 onwards	2,073 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 5,000)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.90 - 12.65	10,355-11,287	2,071-2,257	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	9.75-15.00	10,562-11,895	2,112-2,379	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	11.25 onwards	10,934 onwards	2,187 onwards	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 1 year	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.50-10.00	10,019 - 10,684	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	Up to 0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)]
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.80 - 9.85	10,331 - 10,587	Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 4,000
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.30	10,078 - 10,452	Rs 2,500
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.40 onwards	10,234 onwards	Up to Rs. 8,500
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.12-11.62	10,167 - 11,026	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	7.65-9.00	10,055 onwards	1% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 50,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank*	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
IDFC FIRST Bank	8.99 onwards	10,377 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.30	10,043 - 10,452	0.50%(Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 20,000)

*Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on July 1

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

Taiwan resumes 'anti-communist' classes for graduates, citing threat



U.K.'s Farage referred to standards watchdog after new report of gifts



Next round of U.S.-Iran talks likely to be held at Islamabad: report



Beijing, Moscow to hold joint naval exercises off China's coast today



Attack by Yemen's Houthis kills 16 pro-govt. troops, injures 22: medics

Agence France-Presse
ADEN

Fight for control: A file photo of Houthi rebel fighters chanting slogans as they take off to a battlefield in Sanaa, Yemen. AP

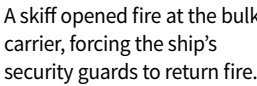
'Some Lebanese villages had asked to be annexed'

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Benjamin Netanyahu

'Cargo ship reports being under attack off coast of Yemen'

Associated Press
CAIRO

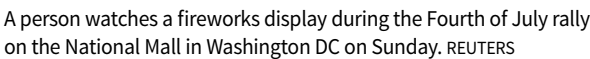


Mojtaba still absent as other sons pay respects to Khamenei

Agence France-Presse
TEHRAN

Trump hails U.S., blasts 'communists' in 250th anniversary celebration speech

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON



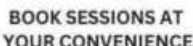
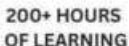
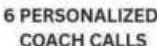
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NEVER-SAY-DIE ATTITUDE

Paraguay coach says his team ‘fought like lions’ against France



REUTERS

Paraguay coach Gustavo Alfaro said his side “fought like lions” in its 0-1 World Cup loss at the hands of France. “France couldn’t find the answers, and it took a bit of individual skill and a penalty given by VAR to make the difference,” Alfaro said after the round-of-16 game at Lincoln Financial Field in Philadelphia.

BITTER PILL TO SWALLOW

Marsch adamant Canada was better than Morocco despite loss



REUTERS

Coach Jesse Marsch insisted that Canada was the better team even though it lost 0-3 to Morocco in the World Cup last 16. “We totally controlled the first half. At the start of the second half, we were the more aggressive team. The way we pushed, the quality we showed and the overall impact... we were better”.

WORDS OF ENCOURAGEMENT

Cape Verde’s Vozinha recalls heartfelt exchange with Messi



AFF

I went up to Lionel Messi after the game. He hugged me and said, “You are great. Your people should be proud of you.” That was incredible for me. Hearing words like that from someone like Messi means a lot to me — Cape Verde goalkeeper Vozinha recalls a heartfelt exchange with the Argentina captain.

BIG BOOST

FIFA revokes Balogun’s one-game ban, forward eligible for last-16 tie



REUTERS

Folarin Balogun’s one-game ban was revoked by FIFA on Sunday, allowing the forward to play in the United States’ World Cup round-of-16-game against Belgium on Monday. Balogun, who has scored three WC goals so far, received a red card for stepping on the foot of Bosnia and Herzegovina’s Tarik Muharemovic.

Mbappe penalty sends France into last eight

Paraguay drags the European heavyweight into frustration for long stretches; the breakthrough arrives after substitute Doue goes down inside the area under Diego Gomez’s challenge

FIFA WORLD CUP

Avon Sengupta
PHILADELPHIA

In the city where the Declaration of Independence was adopted 250 years ago, the Fourth of July had turned Philadelphia into a festival and a furnace.

At Reading Terminal Market, locals mixed with French and Paraguayan supporters over cheesesteaks, pizza slices, and iced drinks, while the bridge above offered a patch of shade from the 42-degree heat.

There was no such cover at the Lincoln Financial Field, where France spent much of the afternoon labouring in the sun before Kylian Mbappe’s penalty finally broke Paraguay’s resistance and sealed a 1-0 win that sent Les Bleus into the World Cup quarterfinals.

The holiday mood had travelled to the stadium as well, where an extended fireworks display entertained the crowd before kick-off. It added a little more heat and a veil of smoke to an already punishing evening, where France was stripped of its usual fluency and reduced to the impatience of a side being made to wait.

For long stretches, Gustavo Alfaro’s side dragged another heavyweight into frustration. Paraguay,



Making no mistake: Mbappe scores the all-important goal from the spot. REUTERS

which had eliminated Germany in the previous round, turned the game into a scrap with its compact defending and relentless closing of space.

France had the ball almost constantly, finishing the first half with more than 80% possession, but not the control it had exerted for much of this tournament.

Didier Deschamps had been forced into a change before kick-off, with Manu Kone brought into the midfield after Aurelien Tchouameni had picked up an injury in training.

Sensing there was little room through the middle, Les Bleus went wide early and almost found a reward

THE RESULT

Round of 16: Paraguay 0 lost to France 1 (Mbappe 70-pen).

when Mbappe narrowly failed to connect with a teasing delivery.

France’s clearest opening before the break came from a quick transition as Mike Maignan released Mbappe into open grass with a quick throw after a Paraguay corner-kick.

Juan Caceres, however, was ready for the sprint race with one of football’s fastest. He matched the Real Madrid forward stride for stride before making a last-ditch clearance.

Paraguay offered little in attack, but Junior Alonso,

Omar Alderete and Gustavo Gomez held their line together, attacking crosses and crowding the box, while those ahead continued to break opposition’s rhythm and add to the frustration inside the French contingent.

France resumed with greater urgency after the interval and in the 54th minute, Ousmane Dembele let fly from distance, drawing an acrobatic save from Orlando Gill, who pushed the ball away at full stretch.

The breakthrough, when it finally came, arrived through VAR rather than open play.

Desire Doue went down inside the area under Diego Gomez’s challenge, and

the referee was sent to the pitch-side monitor, and a sense of dread descended upon the Paraguayan bench.

After a brief review, the spot-kick was awarded and the stadium erupted.

Mbappe stepped up and rolled his penalty low into the corner, as the goalkeeper dived the wrong way.

Gill’s double save to deny Mbappe in stoppage time did little to alter the course of the contest.

This was not France at its fluent best. But, in the end, one penalty was enough to send Deschamps’ side through and leave Paraguay’s rearguard effort unrewarded.

Deschamps praises side for staying cool in a heated clash

Avon Sengupta
PHILADELPHIA

France head coach Didier Deschamps admitted that his team had been dragged into an uncomfortable and fractious World Cup contest against Paraguay but praised his side for keeping its discipline.

“We had some easier games, so it was good for us to face something more complicated. We should have scored a second goal because that would have made things easier, but I am happy with the final outcome. I think this will help us. We looked to play football, but the opponent just defended,” Deschamps said.

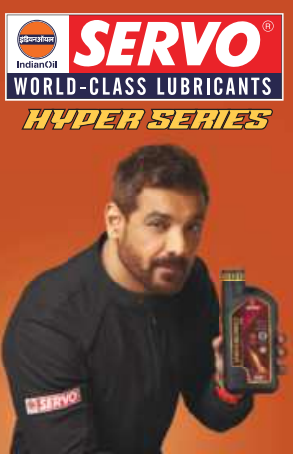
“When a team plays with a low block, you need more effort and intensity.

“Despite the heat, we should have played quicker, especially in transition. But it is easier to play when you are defending deep than when you have to carry the ball, dribble and create in these conditions.”

Deschamps was also pleased with the way his players handled the tension of a game that featured frequent fouls, repeated stoppages and simmering irritation on both benches.



Petulant: Paraguay ‘keeper Gill throws the ball at Mbappe’s back after the latter refused to shake hands. GETTY IMAGES



“We were leading and I told them that if we played their (Paraguay’s) game, we would not win,” he said. “We already had three yellow cards, so I told them – no gestures, no reactions. There were some technical fouls, some actions, some words from

the other bench that I could have done without, but we tried to stay calm. If the bench is calm, it helps the players. If the bench is angry, that gets communicated to them as well.”

Deschamps suggested that France had learned from watching other sides lose control of knockout ties, pointing to Germany’s elimination earlier in the tournament. “I am proud because the whole team kept its cool. If we had responded to provocation, it could have gone bad. Germany responded to it and it is out. I am happy with my team’s behaviour.”

France will face Morocco in the quarterfinals. “Morocco is one of the best teams. We faced it in Qatar, and we have seen it again,” said the chief coach.

Spain eyes revenge in tinderbox against Portugal

Reuters
DALLAS

Spain and Portugal will drag a year’s worth of Iberian needle into the Texas heat on Monday, when the World Cup round of 16 serves up a rematch of last year’s Nations League final and a clash of generations between Cristiano Ronaldo and Lamine Yamal.

For Luis de la Fuente’s side, the loss in the title decider remains the one blot on an otherwise gleaming three-year run that began with the 2023 Nations League crown and has now stretched to 34 matches unbeaten.

Spain, which is smooth on the ball, ruthless in exploiting space and miserly at the back, has not conceded a World Cup goal since its group match against Japan at Qatar 2022. Yet Portugal is no ordinary obstacle, especially with a midfield of Vitinha, Joao Neves and Bruno Fernandes capable of going toe-to-toe with Spain’s technicians.

It also has Nuno Mendes, who is likely to be handed a double shift:



Clash of a generation: Yamal’s precocious talent may bring an end to Ronaldo’s international career. AFP

Tuesday’s matches

ROUND OF 16	
Portugal vs. Spain, 00.30 a.m.	
USA vs. Belgium, 5.30 a.m.	
Argentina vs. Egypt, 9.30 p.m.	

The day and time(s) pertain to India

smother Yamal’s invention and charge upfield whenever Portugal gets the chance. But Spain is far more than one prodigy.

Portugal struggled badly against Croatia to reach the last 16 and had endured

problems in the group stage. Spain, by contrast, has grown into the tournament since beginning with a goalless draw against Cape Verde.

Then there is Ronaldo. When Ronaldo was beginning his quest for 1,000 career goals, Yamal was a baby. On Monday, they meet in a knockout match where one generation may shove another towards the exit.

For two sides that arrived among the favourites to lift the trophy, a round-of-16 exit would feel brutally early.

Stat attack

- 0 Paraguay didn’t pick up a single card in a World Cup match for the first time since 1998 (vs. Nigeria)
- 1 Mbappe is the only player to score three or more goals in the knockout stages of three editions
- 2 Mbappe is the second player, after Messi, to net seven or more goals in two World Cups
- 5 France has won five consecutive games at the football extravaganza for the first time
- 7 Mbappe has gone level with Lato for most game-winning goals in the quadrennial showpiece
- 10 Deschamps has now won the most knockout games in World Cup history
- 11 Mbappe extends his lead for most goals in the knockouts (Ronaldo Nazario, with eight, is second)
- 26.4 Paraguay’s average tackles per game in this tournament, the highest since Argentina in 2006 (also 26.4)
- 150 France has become the fourth country (after Brazil, Germany and Argentina) to score 150 penalties in the marquee event

Compiled by ANIRUDH VELAMURI



Morocco is now a major contender: Ouahbi

Associated Press
HOUSTON

Morocco is heading to the World Cup quarterfinals and coach Mohamed Ouahbi believes that his team has established itself among football’s elite.

Azzedine Ounahi scored twice to lead Morocco to a 3-0 win over Canada in the round of 16 on Saturday and make the country the first African nation to

reach the last-eight stage more than once.

“We are no longer a surprise,” Ouahbi said through an interpreter.

Just the beginning

“Now when people talk about Morocco, we are a major contender. It is a great source of pride. It is only the beginning and I hope that we continue to have runs like this.”

Having already made

history in this World Cup, Morocco has much higher goals. “We want to keep going,” Ouahbi said. “We do not want to stop.”

The Atlas Lions had become the first African team to reach the semifinals in Qatar in 2022. “We are so proud to represent Africa because it is a continent with a lot of talent. Africa deserves to be in the best level in football,” goalkeeper Yassine Bounou said.

SNAPSHOTS

Learnt about leadership when I was four: Khaka

For Switzerland’s World Cup captain Granit Khaka, leadership is a role he learned aged four when he was handed the house keys as his Albanian parents worked overtime to make ends meet in their adopted country. “I think that I learned about leadership when I was four years old,” Khaka told *Stan Sport Football*. “My parents were working during the day, extra work just to get us what we wanted. It is why we are where we are today. I was four and I was given the keys to the house, so I already had responsibility,” the 33-year-old added.

Football Australia throws weight behind coach Popovic

Football Australia has thrown its support behind under-fire head coach Tony Popovic despite some questionable decisions in the World Cup last-32 penalty shootout loss to Egypt. “Every fan will think about what can be done better,” Football Australia chief executive Martin Kugeler said. “But the coaching



Khaka... passionate. AP

staff and Popovic are always in the best place to judge what is needed for the team in that moment. Popovic absolutely has our confidence.”

Recharged to take over Germany, says Klopp

Jurgen Klopp said that he was recharged and “ready” to take the hot seat in the Germany team. Speaking on *Magenta TV*, for whom he was working as a World Cup pundit, Klopp said: “The timing is not perfect. Nevertheless, it is better than it has ever been. I am more than recharged, so I am ready.” Klopp added: “I have an existing contract with Red Bull. I like to honour contracts, but I am interested in talks [with the DFB].”

EDUCATIONPLUS

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John J. Kennedy

India's higher education story over the past decade has been one of transformation. Women are entering universities in unprecedented numbers. In several disciplines, enrolment has crossed 50%. The gender gap, by many measures, is closing. Engineering is the exception. Let's look at numbers. Women account for roughly 28-30% of undergraduate Engineering enrolment, according to the All India Survey on Higher Education 2021-22. That number has barely moved in years. While overall engineering enrolment expanded significantly in the early 2010s, women's share didn't keep pace. The rest of higher education tilted toward gender parity. Engineering stayed still.

Different reality
But even that number flatters the reality. Women in Engineering are heavily concentrated in Computer Science and Electronics. In Mechanical, Civil, and Electrical Engineering, which are the backbone disciplines, female enrolment is often in the single digits at many institutions.

So it's not just that women are under-represented in Engineering broadly. Within Engineering itself, they are being funnelled into a narrow slice of the field. Beyond graduation, the numbers fall off a cliff. Women make up close to a third of Engineering graduates but less than one-fifth of the research and development workforce in Science and Engineering. Somewhere between the degree and the job, a large proportion of women exit and don't come back. This is the "leaky pipeline" problem and it shows up at nearly every stage.



GETTY IMAGES/STOCKPHOTO

Out of circuit

Why women aren't staying in Engineering and what needs to be done

The easy explanation is individual preference. Women choose other fields or they opt out. But that explanation doesn't hold up well under scrutiny, because choices don't happen in a vacuum.

A closer look
In rural and semi-urban settings, girls consistently receive less encouragement in Maths and Science. Access to coaching, which is practically a prerequisite for India's competitive Engineering entrance

exams, skews heavily toward boys, constrained by both money and mobility. Even at the IITs, where active interventions have increased female enrolment in recent years, the proportion has stabilised at around one-fifth. The floor has risen, but the ceiling is staying put.

Then there's the economics of household decision-making. Engineering is expensive. Families making hard choices about where to invest often do so along deeply gendered lines;

sons toward high-cost, high-return professional degrees; daughters toward disciplines perceived as safer, more flexible, more compatible with the life she's expected to lead later. These decisions aren't made maliciously. They're made pragmatically, within a set of assumptions that nobody stops to question.

Interestingly, the workplace is where the pipeline leaks most visibly. Core Engineering sectors such as manufacturing, construction, and heavy indus-

try remain stubbornly male-dominated, and not just in perception. Safety infrastructure is often inadequate. Work-life flexibility is minimal. Career advancement is slow and opaque. Women who graduate with Engineering degrees and enter these environments often migrate toward non-technical roles or leave the field altogether.

Lack of role models
There's also the absence of role models, which matters more than people usually credit. Women are under-represented in Engineering faculty, in industry leadership, and in the rooms where technical decisions get made. That under-representation isn't just a statistic; it shapes what younger women imagine is possible for themselves.

When you rarely see someone who looks like you succeeding in a space, it's rational to wonder whether that space is really for you. What makes this paradoxical is that India actually performs reasonably well in terms of women's overall participation in STEM. The aggregate numbers look decent by international standards. But those numbers obscure a stark internal divide: women entering Science in large numbers, while Engineering, especially its core branches, remains a different story entirely. Policy so far has focused mainly on access: scholarships, outreach, and reserved seats. These matter, but they're not enough. Getting more women into Engineering programmes doesn't solve the problem if the structures governing what happens next remain unchanged.

Looking ahead
So, what's actually needed is intervention across the full arc: school through career. Gender-sensitive teaching in Maths and Science. Affordable preparatory pathways that don't require a family to pay for private coaching. University environments that don't subtly channel women into a handful of "acceptable" specialisations.

Most critically, workplaces that are actually built for a diverse workforce: flexible structures, real anti-harassment mechanisms, clear re-entry pathways for women returning after breaks. The deeper issue isn't access. It's that the entire system, from classroom to boardroom, is still configured around assumptions that don't include women as full participants in engineering. Until that changes, the problem won't.

The writer is former professor and dean, Christ University, Bengaluru

SCHOLARSHIPS

University of Dundee GEMS Scholarship
Offered by the University of Dundee, the U.K.
Eligibility: Students who have secured an offer for a full-time UG course with a tuition fee of at least £21,600 per annum at the GEMS Schools for September 2026 and have qualified for international fee paying status
Rewards: £6,000 annually
Application: Online
Deadline: August 28
www.b4s.in/edge/UGEM2

NSP Pre-Matric Scholarship for Students with Disabilities
Offered by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment, Government of India.
Eligibility: Indian nationals pursuing regular full-time studies in Class 9 or 10 in a recognised school with a disability of 40% or more as defined under the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016, and an annual family income of less than ₹250,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹4,000 and benefits.
Application: Online
Deadline: August 31
www.b4s.in/edge/PMSD7

Nokia Foundation Scholarship
Offered by the Nokia Foundation
Eligibility: Students pursuing a doctoral degree in ICT or related scientific fields in a Finnish University with at least one accepted publication related to doctoral dissertation at the time of applying, and a good academic record.
Rewards: ₹7,500
Application: Online
Deadline: September 15
www.b4s.in/edge/NKSP2

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com



Hindustan Group of Institutions Honour Eminent Personalities at the 5th Edition of Dr. K.C.G. Verghese Excellence Awards 2026

Chennai, June 20, 2026: Hindustan Group of Institutions (HGI), one of India's premier educational institutions, successfully hosted the 5th Edition of the Dr. K.C.G. Verghese Excellence Awards 2026, Chennai. Instituted in memory of the late Dr. K.C.G. Verghese, Founder-Chairman of HGI, the awards recognise individuals whose outstanding achievements and contributions have created a lasting impact in their respective fields. Established in 2009, the awards have evolved into a prestigious platform celebrating excellence, innovation, leadership, and service to society. The 2026 edition honoured 13 distinguished personalities across six categories, namely Lifetime Achievement, Academic & Research Excellence, Corporate Excellence, Alumni Excellence, Corporate Social Responsibility, and Child Prodigy.

The event was presided over by Dr. Anand Jacob Verghese, Chairman, Hindustan Group of Institutions, in the presence of Dr. Elizabeth Verghese, Founder Chairperson; Dr. Ashok George Verghese, Vice President, HGI; Dr. Susan Verghese, Vice President, HGI; Dr. Annie Jacob, Director, KCG College of Technology; Dr. Aby Sam, Executive Director, HGI; Mr. Enid Verghese Jacob, Associate Director, HGI; and Dr. M. Rajaram, IAS (Retd.), Advisor, HGI.

The ceremony was graced by Hon'ble Justice A.D. Jagadish Chandira, Judge, Madras High Court, as the Chief Guest, and Mr. Hugues Boiteau, Scientific and Academic Attaché, Institut Français India, as the Distinguished Guest. The occasion also witnessed the digital launch and unveiling of the HGI 60th Year Commemorative Logo, marking six decades of excellence in education, research, innovation, and nation-building.

Among the recipients, Mr. Biju Balendran, Deputy Managing Director, MG Motor India, was honoured with the Lifetime Achievement Award for his remarkable contributions to the automotive industry.

The same category also recognised Mr. Satish Chandra Gupta, Senior Advisor, IndiGo; Dr. Bashi V. Velayudhan, Director, ICAAD, SIMS Hospitals; and Dr. G.S.K. Velu, Chairman, FICCI Tamil Nadu State Council and Managing Director, Neuberg Diagnostics, for their exemplary contributions to aviation, healthcare, entrepreneurship, and industry leadership.

The Academic & Research Excellence Award was conferred upon Dr. Rajnish Kumar, Professor, Department of Chemical Engineering, IIT Madras, in recognition of his significant contributions to research and higher education.

The Corporate Excellence Award was presented to Lt. Col. V. Shanmuga Velan, Founder and Chief Technology Officer, Elena Geo Systems Pvt. Ltd., for his achievements in technology and innovation.

The Alumni Excellence Awards were presented to Mr. Sisirakanta Dash, Group Chief Strategy Officer, Air India Limited; Mr. P. Senthil Kumar, Global Executive Leader, Ashok Leyland; Mr. Nandakumar Shekar, international football player and HITS alumnus; and Ms. T. Dharshini, national basketball player and HITS alumna, reflecting HGI's legacy of nurturing leaders across diverse domains.

The Corporate Social Responsibility Awards were conferred upon Mr. K. Ramesh, Founder, Mugavari Foundation, and Dr. Saundarya Rajesh, Managing Director, Avtar Group, in recognition of their impactful contributions towards social development and inclusion.

The Child Prodigy Award was presented to Ms. Victoria Isaac (Victoriastic) for her exceptional talent and achievements at a young age.

Addressing the gathering, Dr. Anand Jacob Verghese, Chairman, Hindustan Group of Institutions, stated that the Excellence Awards are a tribute to the values of excellence, innovation, integrity, and service that have guided HGI throughout its 60-year journey. He emphasised that the awards celebrate individuals whose leadership and accomplishments continue to inspire progress across industries and communities. Reaffirming the vision of the institution's Founder, he noted that education remains one of the most powerful instruments of transformation and nation-building and highlighted HGI's commitment to nurturing talent, fostering innovation, strengthening industry-academia collaboration, and developing future-ready professionals.

As Hindustan Group of Institutions commemorates six decades of educational excellence, the Dr. K.C.G. Verghese Excellence Awards continue to reflect its enduring commitment to recognising outstanding achievers, promoting innovation, and contributing meaningfully to national development. Through its focus on quality education, research, entrepreneurship, employability, and industry engagement, HGI remains dedicated to empowering future generations and shaping leaders who can drive positive change in society.



INBRIEF



Gurnoor on fire as India-A seals series against Lanka-A

Pacer Gurnoor Brar made a strong case for a Test debut in Sri Lanka next month as he bagged a match haul of 10 wickets in India-A's resounding 10-wicket win in the second and final 'Test' against Sri Lanka-A here on Sunday. The Dhruv Jurel-led side thus clinched the series 1-0.

The scores: Sri Lanka-A 366 & 209 in 48.3 overs (Bandara 87, Gurnoor 6/68) lost to India-A 543/9 in 143.3 overs (Sai Sudharsan 168, Padikkal 94, Jurel 53, Saransh 70 n.o., Nuwantha 5/159, Sudeera 3/102) & 36/0 in 6.2 overs.

Sri Lanka's Dinusha and Kusal thwart West Indies

Sonal Dinusha and Kusal Mendis put on 143 for the sixth wicket as Sri Lanka declares its first innings at 549 for nine against the West Indies on the second day of the second Test in Antigua on Saturday. West Indies lost Brandon King (17) in 24 overs before stumps and finished 58 for one, still 491 runs behind.

The scores: Sri Lanka 549/9 decl. in 139.3 overs (Udara 188, Kamindu 84, Kusal 69, Dinusha 92) vs West Indies 58/1 in 24 overs.

ENGAGEMENTS

Cricket: TNCA league, I div., fifth round, Swaraj vs. Vijay (Wahe Guru-A); Grand Slam vs. Globe Trotters (Tagore); Jolly Rovers vs. Nelson (Murugappa); MRC-A vs. Pristine (Gojan-A); Singam Pulis vs. Sea Hawks (Gojan-B); SKM vs. Young Stars (Madras Cricket Ground, Vanagaram), day two, 9.30 a.m.;

TNCA City Schools under-16 inter-school, St. Mary's vs Chetti-nad Vidayashram (University Union); Velammal Vidyalaya-A, Alapakkam vs Dr. Vimala Convent (MIT Ground); Velammal Vi-dyalaya-B, Alapakkam vs Babaji Vidhyashram (Sumangali Mat); Jawahar Vidyalaya SSS-B vs Sunshine Chennai (SMK Fomra 'B' Ground); Jeppiaar CBSE School vs P.S. Senior (Al-stom-A); Avichi vs Heartfulness International-B (Alston-B); Don Bosco-B vs Sri Chaitanya Techno School, (SMK Fomra-A); Marg Vidhyalaya vs Sir Sivaswami Kalalaya (Gandhi Nagar), 8 a.m.;

APL Global School vs Sri Sankara S.S.S. (University Union); Santhome-A vs MCC (MIT Ground); KRM Public School vs Sir Mutha School-B (Sumangali Mat); Agurchand Mannull Jain School vs St. Patrick's (SMK Fomra-B); K.S.N. Senior vs DAV Pu-blic School (Alston-A); Alagappa MHSS, Purasawalkam vs PSBB-A, K.K. Nagar (Alston-B); Govt. H.S.S-B, West Mambalam vs DAV Boys Gopalapuram (SMK Fomra-A); PSBB, Nungambak-kam vs The Shri Ram Universal School (Gandhi Nagar), 1 p.m.

LIVE TELECAST

Zimbabwe vs Bangladesh: 1st ODI, FanCode, 1 p.m.
Wimbledon: Star Sports 1, 2, SS Select 1, 2 & JioHotstar, 3.30 p.m.
West Indies vs Sri Lanka: Second Test, Day 4, FanCode, 7.30 p.m.
FIFA World Cup: Unite8 Sports 1, 2 & Z5 App, 12.30 & 5.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Zuccaro wins feature event in record time

RACING

BENGALURU: P. Shroff-trained Zuccaro (G. Vivek up) won in re-cord time the Maharaja's Gold Cup (2,200m), the feature event of the races held here on Sunday (July 5).

The winner is owned by Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt Ltd rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunjibhoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Vispi R. Patel, Mr. A.S. Nariel-wala, Mr. Eruch Adi Mody, Miss. Anita J. Captain, Mr. Dinshaw P. Adenwalla & Mrs. Jasmine D. Adenwalla.

THE RESULTS:
1. LAGARDE PLATE (1,200M): N R I ACE (Jagadeesh) 1, Power Of Beauty (Arul) 2, Crosswater (Aleemuddin) 3 and Stellantis (S. Sachin) 4. Not run: Never Give In. Shd, 1-3/4 and 1-1/4. Im, 12.36s. ₹116 (w), 30 and 10 (p), SHP: 25, THP: 23, FP: 189, Q: 59, Trinella: 406/275, Exacta: 629/359. Favour-ite: Power Of Beauty.

Owner: Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: Md. Sajid Qureshi.
2. R.R. BYRAMJI MEMORIAL PLATE (1,200M): AZAADI (G. Vivek) 1, Aprameya (Neeraj) 2, Shadai (Ak-shay K) 3 and Protieux (S. Shareef) 4. 4-3/4, 2 and 1. Im, 12.77s. ₹16 (w), 12, 10 and 21 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 41, FP: 30, Q: 31, Trinella: 169/83, Exacta: 789/383. Favourite: Azadi.

Owners: Mr. Atul Ishwardas Chor-dia, Mr. Raj Ramprasad Singh, Mr. Marthand Singh Mahindra & Mrs. Rina Mahindra. Trainer: P.S. Chouhan.
3. A.M.C. GOWDA MEMORIAL TROPHY (1,200M): ENCINO (Sandesh) 1, Gloriousness (Suraj) 2, See The Light (Akshay K) 3 and Idi Minnal (Vinod Shinde) 4. Not run: Thessalian. 7-1/4, 2-1/2 and 1-1/2. Im, 10.06s. ₹13 (w), 11, 13 and 15 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 44, FP: 38, Q: 34, Trinella: 61/43, Exacta: 868/679. Favourite: Encino.

Owners: Gainsville Stud & Agrl Farm Pvt Ltd, Mr. Kishore Rungta, Mr. S.R. Sanas & Mr. Ajay K. Arora. Trainer: Adhiraj S. Jodha.

4. MAHARAJA'S GOLD CUP (2,200M): ZUCCARO (G. Vivek) 1, Mayne Magic (Antony) 2, Alf-onsine (A. Asbar) 3 and Redefined (Akshay K) 4. 2-1/4 and 2. 2m, 13.75s (record time). ₹14 (w), 11, 22 and 21 (p), SHP: 51, THP: 42, FP: 77, Q: 64, Trinella: 217/51, Exacta: 1,688/1,275. Favourite: Zuccaro.

Owners: Five Stars Shipping Co Pvt Ltd rep. by Mr. K.N. Dhunjib-hoy, Mr. Z.K. Dhunjibhoy, Ms. Anosha Meyers, Mr. Vispi R. Patel, Mr. A.S. Narielwala, Mr. Eruch Adi Mody, Miss. Anita J. Captain, Mr. Dinshaw P. Adenwalla & Mrs. Jas-mine D. Adenwalla. Trainer: P. Shroff.

5. GALILEE PLATE (1,800M): MAN-DATE (Aleemuddin) 1, Angelisa (Yash) 2, Stentorian (Darshan) 3 and Sassy (Kiran Rai) 4. Shd, 6-1/2 and 2-1/2. Im, 51.88s. ₹46 (w), 12, 12 and 16 (p), SHP: 30, THP: 42, FP: 198, Q: 84, Trinella: 621/403, Exacta: 3,344/2,006. Favourite: Stalingrad.

Owners: Mr. Haider Soomar, Mr. Rajan Aggarwal & Mr. Chandrakanth Kankaria. Trainer: Arjun Mangalorkar.

6. SOUTHERN EMPIRE PLATE (1,400M): ABSOLUTE FORCE (Sandesh) 1, My Solitaire (Ab-hishek Mhatre) 2, Shahenshaah (Faizan Khan) 3 and Ebotse (Ant-ony) 4. Not run: Disruptor and Gandofini. 1-1/2, 2-1/2 and 3/4. Im, 25.91s. ₹26 (w), 12, 47 and 73 (p), SHP: 147, THP: 138, FP: 1,085, Q: 491, Trinella: 44,455 (c/o); Exacta: 31,348/13,434. Favourite: Absolute Force.

Owner: Mr. Raj Ramprasad Singh. Trainer: Joseph B. Awale. Jackpot: ₹1,524. Runner-up: 196. Mini Jackpot: 946; Treble (i): 1,440; (ii): 541.

Sai Kishore leaving no stone unturned to return to his best

The 29-year-old is part of the targeted spinners' camp to be held at the BCCI's Centre of Excellence

CRICKET

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

A year after playing 15 matches for the Gujarat Titans in 2025, Tamil Nadu left-arm spinner R. Sai Kishore had to be content warming the benches mostly in this year's IPL featuring only in three matches.

“The thing is, we are playing a team sport, luckily or unluckily. I think I prepared really well. But it was very disappointing that I was not getting my chances. So I think I have to be very consistent in how I prepare, how I show up,” said a candid Sai Kish-

ore on the sidelines of the TNCA annual day on Saturday.

Even in red-ball cricket, the 29-year-old's stocks were high in 2024 after finishing as the highest wick-et-taker in the Ranji Tro-phy (2023-24). However, two quiet seasons since then – partly because of unfortunate injuries – have seen the likes of Ma-nav Suthar and Harsh Du-bey rise above him in the pecking order.

Now, ahead of the new season, the left-arm spin-ner is leaving no stone un-turned to get back amongst the reckoning. He will be part of the targeted spin-ners' camp to be held at the BCCI's Centre of Excel-lence in Bengaluru from Ju-

ly 10 to 17 after missing out on it last year.

“I think we always have to improve our game. I'm working closely with R. Ramkumar on my tech-nique and building my vol-ume. I'm very honest with myself. If I really deserve something, it has to come to me. So I have that faith in God,” he said.

On his interaction with TN's new head coach Yo Mahesh, Sai Kishore said, “He's a very vibrant guy. I played with him in First Class in my debut season. I am looking forward to working with him. I think it's very inspiring that the u-23 team did the double last year. If the senior team does well, together we will all rise,” said Sai Kishore.



Eager to improve: Sai Kishore said that he is working closely with Ramkumar on his technique. FILE PHOTO: BISWARANJAN ROUT

AROUND THE CITY

Vishvesh, Harshan star for Omega International

Vishvesh Vellai Rathinam's 124 and H. Harshan's six-for powered Omega International (NIOS) to a 233-run win over St. John's Public School in the final of the CIOC under-14 inter-school tournament recently.

The scores: Omega 294/8 in 50 overs (Vishvesh Vellai Rathinam 124, Aadhil Asrani 31, S. Yadunaath 39, S. Vidhuthajai 3/46) bt St. John's Public School 61 in 25 overs (Om Kumar 32, H. Harshan 6/12).

Special awards: **Best batter:** V. Sachin (St. Bede's); **Best bowler:** Harshan (Omega NIOS); **Best fielder:** Bernis Joemer (St. Michael's Adyar); **Best wicketkeeper:** Ajay (Jeppiaar CBSE); **Player-of-the-Final:** Vishvesh (Omega NIOS); **Player-of-the-Series:** Harshan (Omega NIOS).

Tharun enters final

S. Tharun (RTTHPC) defeated S. Preyesh 13-11, 11-5, 11-6, 11-7 in the men's semifinals while N. Sharvani (Mylapore club) beat M. Ananya (Chennai Achievers) 11-6, 11-7, 12-10, 15-13 in the women's category of the SBM Group-third TNTTA State-ranking table tennis tournament conducted by

Tiruvallur District at the ICF Indoor Stadium on Sunday.

Other results (semifinals):
men: K. Umesh (RTTHPC) bt S. Karthikeyan (Chennai) 11-8, 18-20, 11-9, 6-11, 4-11, 11-8, 11-8.
Women: Selena Deepti (RTTHPC) bt A. Shriya (SK Academy) 14-12, 11-8, 14-12, 11-9.

U-19 boys: S. Sriram (Chennai Achievers) bt M. Mohammed (SK Academy) 12-10, 11-6, 9-11, 11-4; S. Mehan (Chennai Achievers) bt Akash Rajavelu (SK Academy) 11-3, 11-7, 11-3.

U-19 girls: B.R. Nandhini (MVM) bt R. Mercy (ACE TTA) 7-11, 11-7, 11-6, 11-8; M. Ananya (Chennai Achievers) bt N. Sharvani (Mylapore Club) 11-5, 11-5, 11-7.

U-17 boys: M. Mohammed (SK Academy) bt Akash Rajavelu (SK Academy) 11-6, 11-5, 12-10; J. N. Sanjey Arwindh (SK Academy) bt Vishruth Ramakrishnan (MST) 11-9, 4-11, 11-9, 16-14.

U-17 girls: M. Ananya (Chennai Achievers) bt R. Mercy (ACE TTA) 13-11, 12-10, 11-8; M.R. Moksha (SK Academy) bt O.P. Poojashri (Himalaya TTA) 6-11, 12-10, 11-9, 11-4.

U-15 boys: J.N. Sanjey Arwindh (SK Academy) bt T. Lokjith Gandhi (SK Academy) 11-9, 11-7, 11-8; Krish Vinodh (Vinwin) bt M. Ashvajiith (SK Academy) 9-11, 3-11, 11-6, 11-9, 11-6.

U-15 girls: B. Varnica (SSA-ERD) bt Samyra Rajesh (ITTC) 11-7, 13-11, 11-7; H. Thanishkaa (Bestshot TTA) bt A. Bavithra (LCC- Neyveli) 11-9, 11-8, 15-13.
U-13 boys: R. Sujeth (Bestshot TTA) bt M. Tanishragrav

(Krishnagiri) 6-11, 11-9, 11-4, 13-11; H. Tanish (SK Academy) bt Siddharth Adhithyan (SSH) 11-4, 11-5, 11-7.

U-13 girls: D. Pratika (SSA-ERD) bt N. Sahana (Bestshot TTA) 11-9, 11-9, 13-11; V.G. Harshika (Madurai) bt Ujjayani Niyogi (RTTHPC) 8-11, 11-9, 11-5, 11-6.

U-11 boys: M. Muhammad Rehan (ITTC) bt Akhil Vinodh (Vinwin) 6-11, 14-12, 7-11, 11-5, 11-9; T.K. Akshath (Dronacharya TTA) bt M. Nibhish (SKJ-Salem) 11-3, 9-11, 7-11, 11-7, 11-5.

U-11 girls: H. Dhiya (Bestshot TTA) bt M.K. Rudhrasree (Vinwin) 11-5, 11-2, 13-11; D. Lathikasree (BTTA) bt S. Yasika Sasha (Udagamandalam) 11-8, 11-5, 11-4.

U-9 boys: Divit Jain (SK Academy) bt Kavinesh (SK Academy) 11-2, 11-1, 11-3; S. Adhvik (MAK Chandra) bt Vihaan Skandaa Gokul (MST) 11-9, 11-8, 8-11, 11-2.

U-9 girls: N. Yanthi (Coimbatore) bt D. Adithi (Towers Club TTA) 11-8, 11-5, 11-7; Sharadha Ramakrishnan (MST) bt Kashvi (Table Tennis for all) 7-11, 11-9, 11-4, 11-5.

Veterans: G. Vinodh (SRSA) bt J. Rajkumar (SSH) 11-5, 5-11, 11-7, 11-9; L. Vigneshwaran (SSH) bt R. Rajesh (LIC) 8-11, 11-7, 11-9, 6-11, 11-8.

Corporates: G. Prasanna Kumar (SK Academy) bt J. Sriram (Towers Club TTA) 11-7, 11-7, 11-9; L. Vigneshwaran (SSH) bt Madhav (ITTC) 11-13, 11-7, 12-10, 11-3.

Big wins for Tiruvallur and Chengalpattu

Sports Bureau
TIRUVALLUR

Host Tiruval-lur coasted to a nine-wicket win over Kan-cheepuram in the TNCA inter-district u-16 tourna-ment for the 127 n.o.). P.R. Thevar Trophy on Sunday. J. Kabilan's unbea-ten 127 set up Chengalpat-tu's 207-run win over Tiru-chi at Tiruvannamalai.

The scores: Zone-A (Tiruvallur): Kancheepuram 121 in 45.5 overs (R. Sarvin Raj 4/23) lost to Tiruvallur 122/1 in 28 overs (R. Vishwa 51 n.o., S. Gautam Anand 51).
Zone-H (Tiruvannamalai): Chengalpattu 307/8 in 50 overs (J. Kabilan 127 n.o.), S. Hashvamithran 41, V. Srirajarajan 33, R. Rishi 32, S. Mohamad Umar 3/54) bt Tiruchi 100/9 in 50 overs (Rakesh 45 n.o., N. Jeeva 4/3, B. Akshadh Rao 3/34).

Mithul, Aditty star for Young Stars

TNCA FIRST DIVISION

Sports Bureau

M. Mithul Raj (110, 236b, 10x4) and Aditty Varadh-arajan (107 batting, 255b, 10x4, 1x6) stitched togeth-er a commanding 189-run second-wicket partner-ship as Young Stars CC reached 229 for two against SKM CC at stumps on the opening day of the TNCA first division league fifth-round match at the Madras Cricket Ground on Sunday.

The scores: At Wahe-Guru-A: Swaraj 288/8 in 87 overs (Siddarth Prakash 34, L. Ramnath 56, Anuraag Rajesh Nair 30, R. Javed Mohammed 90 batting, Ashwanth Valthapa 46, Nidhish S. Rajagopal 3/38) vs Vijay. **Toss:** Swaraj.

At Madras Cricket Grounds: Young Stars 229/2 in 90 overs (M. Mithul Raj 110, Aditty Varadarajan 107 batting) vs

Pragg goes behind in blitz

Press Trust of India
ZAGREB

Grandmaster R. Praggna-nandhaa could not repli-cate his rapid form, ma-naging just 3.5 points from the opening nine rounds of the blitz section, while Ali-reza Firouzja produced a brilliant display to emerge as the sole leader after the penultimate day of the Croatian leg of the Grand Chess Tour.

Starting of the day with a win over Keymer, Pragg-naandhaa took a draw in the next game with Giri but followed it up with four straight losses.

The standings: 1. Firouzja Alireza 20; 2-3. Maxime Vachier-Lagrave, Nodirbek Abdusattorov 17 each.
4. R. Praggananandhaa 15.5; 5. D. Gukesh 13.5; Vincent Keymer 13; 7. Anish Giri 12.5.
8. Deac Bogdan-Daniel 11.5; Jordan van Forest 9.5; 10. Ivan Saric 5.



Mithul (110), Aditty (107 batting, both Young Stars).

SKM. **Toss:** Young Stars.
At Tagore College: Grand Slam 243/4 in 89 overs (Abhinav Kannan 71, L. Suryapprakash 44, Aditya Venkatesh 68) vs Globe Trotters. **Toss:** Grand Slam.
At TI-Murugappa: Jolly Rovers 254/6 in 90 overs (R. Vimal Khumar 76, P. Khush Bardia 54, B. Indrajith 50, S. Ganesh 44) vs Nelson. **Toss:** Rovers.
At Gojan-A: MRC-A 240/6 in 84 overs (A.P. Ananda Kumar 48, Kiran Karthikeyan 61, S. Mohamed Ali 42) vs Pristine. **Toss:** Pristine.
At Gojan-B: Singam Pulis 185 in 77 overs (K. Aashiq 42, R. Sibi 33, J. Suresh Kumar 33, H. Trilok Nag 3/44, Daryl S. Ferrario 3/42) vs Sea Hawks 33/1 in 12.4 overs. **Toss:** Sea Hawks.



GOVERNMENT OF INDIA – DEPARTMENT OF SPACE CONSTRUCTION & MAINTENANCE GROUP, SDSC – SHAR SRIHARIKOTA – 524124

Brief E-TENDER NOTICE

No: SHAR: CMG CIVIL:MAINT:E-PT-05/26-27Dt: 02.07.2026

On behalf of President of India, Item Rate tenders are invited through e-tendering for following works:

Name of Work	Tender No	Estimate Cost
Term contract for Civil & PH works for SLC complex, Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadulex Rasayani).	T/C-26-008	₹ 60.00 Lakhs

Tender documents can be downloaded up to 17.07.2026, 14:30 hrs. For eligibility criteria and other details, interested tenderers may please refer to the detailed bilingual (Hindi-English) Notice Inviting Tenders (NIT) on the website <https://www.isro.gov.in/Tenders.html> and tender free view at <https://www.tenderwizard.com/isro>

Sd/- GROUP HEAD, CMG/ SDSC SHAR

ଓଡ଼ିଶା ବିଦ୍ୟୁତ୍ ଶକ୍ତି ସଂଚାରଣ ନିଗମ ଲିମିଟେଡ୍



ODISHA POWER TRANSMISSION CORPORATION LIMITED

(A Government of Odisha Undertaking)

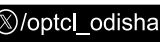
Regd. Office: OPTCL Tech Tower, Janpath, Saheed Nagar, Bhubaneswar-751007

NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER

E-Tender No.	Tender Description:	Estimated Cost
CPC-46/2026-27	Bids invited in e-tender mode under single stage two part bidding system for Providing group health insurance coverage for the regular employees and retired employees of OPTCL. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 09.07.2026 upto 17:30 P.M.	-
CPC-52/2026-27	Bids invited under single stage two part system for Engineering, supply, erection, testing & commissioning of augmentation of Atri Sub-station capacity from 320MVA (2 X 160MVA) to 480MVA(3 X 160 MVA) at 220kV level through construction of 220kV & 132kV 3rd 160MVA Auto Transformer Bay and 60MVA (1X40+1X20 MVA) to 110MVA (1X50+1X40+1X20 MVA) at 132kV level through construction of 132 kV & 33kV 3rd 50MVA Power Transformer Bay in Khurda District on turnkey contract basis in e- tendering mode only. Last Date & Time of Submission of Bid: 27.07.2026 upto 12:45 P.M.	Rs. 7,72,61,507/-

Complete set of bidding documents are available at www.tenderwizard.com/OPTCL and www.optcl.co.in.

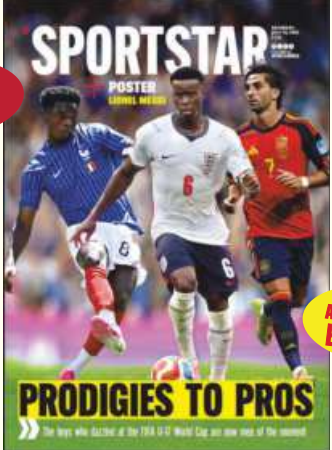




HIPR-35/2026-27



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A CH-CHE



Y.B. Sarangi

Ancy Sojan, having eclipsed Anju Bobby George's 22-year-old National mark of 6.83m set at the 2004 Athens Olympics, has a clear target: the Asian Games gold in Aichi-Nagoya in September this year.

"I want to bring the gold medal with a high class jump. I am aiming for the Asian Games record also so that I can directly qualify for the World championship next year. 6.86m is the qualification mark (for the Worlds) and the qualifying period will start from August 23," said Ancy, who clinched a silver medal at the last Asian Games in 2023 with a jump of 6.63m. She is now the Asian season leader, thanks to her effort of 6.88m at the National inter-State athletics meet in Bhubaneswar recently

On her exceptional performance in hot and humid conditions, Ancy – who had recorded her personal best of 6.75m at the Federation meet in Ranchi in May – said, "I came here to do my personal best and be a good world class performer. I didn't aim for the National Record."

She was relieved with the breakthrough. "Finally it happened, I felt like I was getting tired but I remembered 'What if I go to represent our country and if I feel tired?' Suddenly, I remembered my last Asian Games and I got a boost. With all the belief, I took a good breath and jumped, it happened."

She's happy with the progress but wants more. "I am so happy that I am improving. I think, let's aim higher than this.

An experiment

"Mentally and physically it's like an experiment. You get tired but still you have to jump because you train for that. I want the energy, after 10 jumps I want to stay the same. Each and every training session I am thinking about the target I want to achieve, so that it helps me push more. Today I thought I was competing in the Asian Games and I felt that someone could beat me, so I needed to grab the medal for our nation. Suddenly it encouraged me, it's fun."

For Ancy, the record-breaking jump, which pushed her to seventh place among world leaders this season, sent a message. "This is a statement that India also has good jumpers, if someone works hard she can achieve it. Just believe in yourself, be patient and be dedicated to our work. People will say things but never mind, be true to yourself. I do the same."

The build-up to her remarkable performance in Bhubaneswar started after the Ranchi meet. "After that (Ranchi), I trained hard the same way. Every training I just aimed at what I wanted to be... focusing on technique, run-up and fitness. Each session I pushed hard, I just stuck to my plan.

"Lots of people asked me why you didn't push for the Commonwealth Games qualification. I knew this jump was not easy, so I needed more time for training. I just focused on training only, so I could get there. This was the only (qualifying) competition for the Asian Games. I worked hard and finally got a good result. We had a good plan, God helped us."

The record wasn't Ancy's target. "I was not chasing the record actually. I didn't have any records in my name at the National level. I wanted to do my personal best and a world class jump. Because I am aiming to compete at the international level. I see their enthusiasm. I had competed before in my first Commonwealth (in 2022 and did 6.25m). I was a beginner and I saw people jumping. It was like literally enraged me, their speed and ability. So I felt like I could also do the same. If I want to be like them, I need to jump like them. I aim to become a world class jumper. I want to keep improving. I want to be consistent with that."

The competition had tense moments. "Before my first jump, I was under a little bit of pressure, I wanted to be safe. But the first jump I did in my lifetime, 7m-plus jump. I was so happy and tension-free. In between, there were some fouls and minor issues. Then I was a little tired, so I went to my coach (Anoop Joseph), because I felt some stomach issues. He said, 'Nothing, you are okay.' It charged me up, suddenly I got goosebumps and my eyes got wet.

I want to win gold at the Asian Games

Ancy is super-charged for the continental event in Aichi-Nagoya in September; she is keen to keep raising the bar after rewriting Anju's 22-year-old National mark



BISWARANJAN ROUT & ANI

"I then remembered a scene... I was watching a reel of the film on Milkha Singh. He is wearing the India blazer and is asked 'Who told you to wear this?' And he says, 'I am just trying this.' Suddenly the coach comes and hits him and says, 'If you want to wear the Indian jersey, you have to beat him (your opponent). His coach insisted, 'Tell him you have to beat him.' Finally Milkha says, 'Yes.' It really inspired me. The same thing I tell myself, you have to beat that. And finally the moment happened."

A legend

For Ancy, her senior Kerala Statemate Anju remains an inspiration. "I knew Anju ma'am had a huge jump, 6.83m. She struggled a lot (to reach there). She is a legend. I am aiming to be like her, I want to become a world class jumper.

"I want to say that ma'am is truly an inspiration. I recently read that she has one kidney and her story inspired me a lot. I saw her jump several times and I knew how hard she trained for that also. I hope ma'am is happy about this and would support me."

Ancy looked back at the hormonal issues that had held her back last year. "I had some hormonal issues, I was not able to get fit like this. This year I sacrificed a lot of food and decided that I wanted to become a world class jumper. Even my coach reminded me, 'If you sacrifice and be dedicated, you will get the result. If you want to jump like a top performer,

you will have to train like that.' So if I feel tired during training, I say, 'You have to do it.' It helps me to push harder and train.

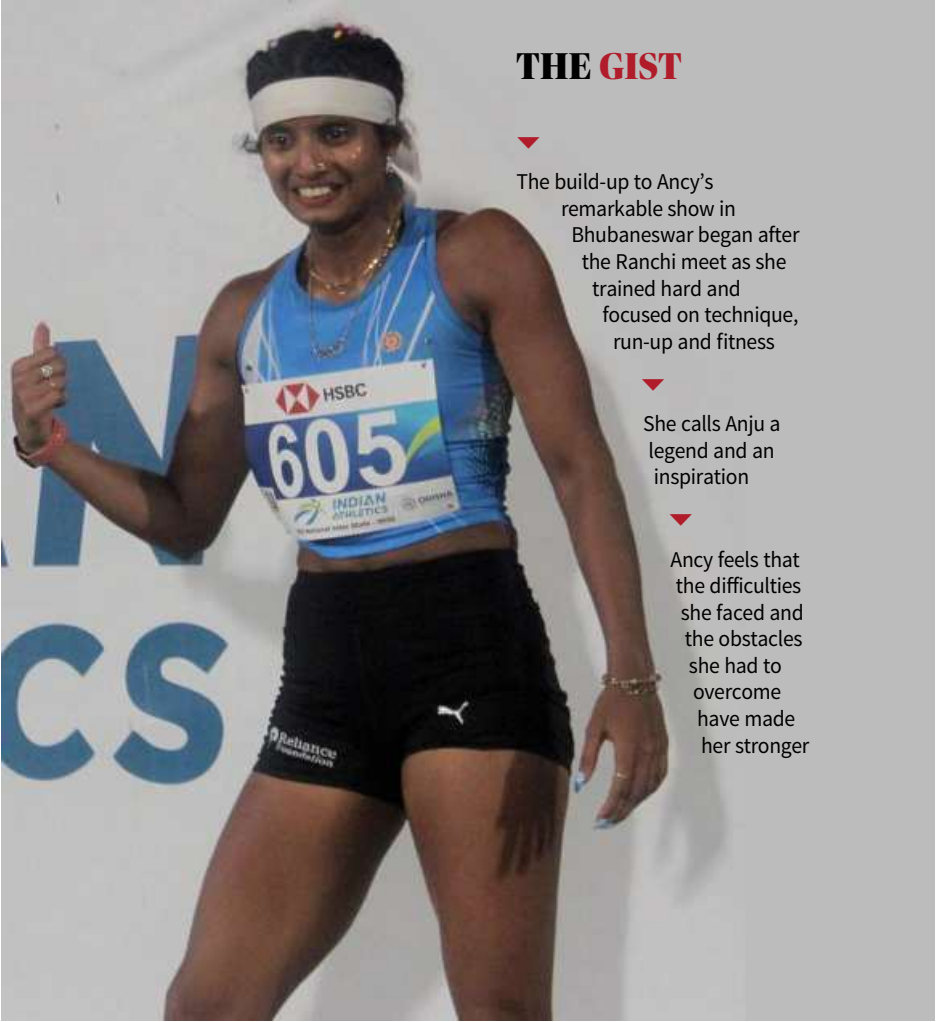
"I am mentally more stable than before. The experience, the difficulties and the obstacles have made me stronger. And God is helping me. I never thought it would happen. I was missing the mark narrowly because of some mistakes. But finally it happened."

Disciplined lifestyle

Ancy doesn't regret maintaining a disciplined lifestyle. "I love to eat a lot of food. But I remember why I am here. I tell myself, 'First you achieve your goal, then eat.' All the sacrifices including social media, food, whatever, will get you the result.

"I reduced my food quantity because of the hormonal issues as I used to put on weight. It is very hard to jump with a lot of weight. Last year I struggled with that. This year my diet is good. I started early, took time and prepared very well. I followed my coach's advice. I got the result. Now I am 55kg. Before this, it was 63kg. Now my body fat is 13% after coming down from 26%."

Ancy rides on her renewed confidence as she approaches the Asian Games. "This year I want to bring gold and hear the National anthem of India. I love biryani and rice. Now I completely avoid that. Maybe, I will have that after the Asian Games," she said.



THE GIST

The build-up to Ancy's remarkable show in Bhubaneswar began after the Ranchi meet as she trained hard and focused on technique, run-up and fitness

She calls Anju a legend and an inspiration

Ancy feels that the difficulties she faced and the obstacles she had to overcome have made her stronger

Milk production in Gangetic plains has nosedived due to climate change

A new study has found that global warming acutely affects dairy production across the Global South, especially the high milk production tract of Haryana as lactating animals are more prone to heat stress; hence, they divert energy from milk production to regulate body temperature, resulting in a 20-30% decline in milk yield

Divya Gandhi
BENGALURU

A massive decline in bovine milk production in India, especially among buffaloes in the trans-Gangetic plains of northwestern India – one of the country’s biggest sources of milk – has now been attributed to climate change. The phenomenon has a profound impact on the milk industry that caters to consumers every day.

While climate change significantly undermines livestock productivity worldwide, a new study published in *Scientific Reports* has found that global warming acutely affects dairy production across the Global South, especially “the high milk production tract of Haryana.”

India is the world’s largest milk producer. Scientists studied data to assess the impact of climatic variables – including yearly minimum, maximum, and mean temperatures, heavy rainfall, temperature-humidity index – and evapotranspiration on milk yield and production in buffaloes, indigenous cattle, and cross-bred cattle in Haryana, spanning over a decade, from 2004 to 2019.

They studied livestock populations across 1,148 villages, which included 4.66 million cross-bred cattle, 2.86 million indigenous cattle and 35.56 million buffaloes.

The study documented milk yield in these three bovine categories and found that high temperatures (over 38 degrees Celsius), in combination with high humidity (over 70%) during July and August (summer and monsoon when humidity peaks) “significantly reduce milk production.” Interestingly, temperatures in winters had a negligible effect.

Adaptive strategies

Critically, evapotranspiration in May and June was an important factor, as was the temperature-humidity index and heatwaves. Solar radiation, ambient temperature, and vapour pressure were part of the climate impact assessments. In light of the fact that agrarian livelihood is likely to be affected profoundly with global warming, “these results underscore [potential evapotranspiration’s] role in shaping adaptive strategies for sustainable livestock production,” the paper said.

Buffaloes, with their darker hue and bare skin are particularly vulnerable to absorb solar radiation. They also have fewer sweat glands than cattle: so, a unit increase in potential evapotranspiration (mm/day) reduces milk yield by around 1.4 litres per buffalo per day, the paper says.

Likewise, cross-bred cattle showed a significant decline in productivity during heatwaves too; but not indigenous cattle breeds such as Sahiwal and Haryana, perhaps because of their adaptation, such as loose skin, efficient sweating and lower metabolic heat production.

The higher the temperature-humidity



Beyond the direct impact of climate change on the health of the cattle, increasing temperatures are also affecting the broader dairy production system, like reduced production and availability of fodder and feed, increasing water scarcity and raising instances of pest and disease attacks. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

index the greater is the impact on livestock physiology and productivity: they eat less, and the heat triggers homeostatic responses “in the form of panting, sweating and reduced activity,” the paper said.

The stress hormones and raised cortisol levels “impairs milk ejection and thereby causes a drop in milk yield and, in severe cases, livestock mortality,” says the paper.

Indigenous cattle

Fodder also becomes a casualty of rising surface temperature, affecting the livestock production system: changes are triggered in the quantity, quality and seasonal availability of feed and fodder. The paper estimates that such stressors in India lead to a loss of 3.2 million tonnes of milk, which is worth ₹2,661 crore in monetary losses that could rise to 15 million tonnes by 2050s.

Abhinav Gaurav, lead advisor for sustainable dairy at Environmental Defense Fund India, a Delhi-based non-profit, told *The Hindu* that heat stress has a significant impact on the milk productivity, health, and well-being of cattle and buffaloes.

“During the intense summer months, the lactating animals are more vulnerable to heat stress, given that animals divert energy from milk production to regulate body temperature, resulting in a 20-30% decline in milk yield.”

Beyond the direct impact of climate change on animals’ health, production and wellbeing, increasing temperatures and prolonged summers are also affecting the broader dairy production system, like reduced production and availability of fodder and feed, increasing water scarcity, raising instances of pest and



Given that India is the largest milk producer and consumer of the world, these production losses will put the livelihoods and nutrition of millions at risk

ABHINAV GAURAV
Lead advisor at Environmental Defense Fund India

disease attacks and compromised animal immune system.

Dr. Gaurav quoted a report in *The Lancet* that estimates that climate change-induced temperature rise can reduce Indian milk production by 25% by 2085.

“Given that India is the largest milk producer and consumer of the world, these production losses will put the livelihoods and nutrition of millions at risk, especially the 80 million smallholder dairy farmers who contribute 85% of the total milk production,” he said.

Haryana’s farmers, interestingly, “were not only well aware of ... technologies and practices but implemented them in the summer season (provided wallowing ponds to buffalo, agroforestry, keeping livestock in shed, alteration of microclimate via sprinklers, foggers, mist, etc., feeding management), and reduced the negative effects of the extremes [of] summer months,” the paper, which was authored by researchers from the ICAR-National Dairy Research Institute and other collaborating institutions, concluded.

Traits to tolerate heat

Indigenous cattle are more tolerant to heat stress, and maintain homeostasis

(that is, they are better at regulating their internal environment), with more advanced evaporative cooling compared to buffaloes. Besides, “indigenous breeds show stronger immunity against local parasites and pathogens. This resilience indirectly supports climate tolerance, since heat stress often compromises immune function,” the authors wrote.

The National Bureau of Animal Genetic Resources has identified heat-tolerance traits in cattle, such as heat shock proteins, coat colour, and hair characteristics, said Dr. Gaurav.

And the research showed that the Sahiwal breed of cattle is significantly more heat-tolerant than exotic breeds with comparable milk productivity.

“The findings underscore the need for a strategic shift toward resilience oriented livestock management. We recommend the integration of potential evapotranspiration and temperature-humidity index ... into regional early warning systems to allow for proactive management,” it added. “Furthermore, long-term climate resilience should prioritise thermo-tolerant breeding programs that leverage *Bos indicus* traits.”

The text concluded that indigenous breeds should be conserved as “reservoirs of climate-resilient traits,” and policies must prioritise *in-situ* conservation and farmer-led breed improvement programmes.

“The larger challenge now lies in scaling these solutions for millions of smallholder farmers, who often face limited awareness, inadequate financial resources, and the absence of a coordinated national climate-smart dairy strategy,” Dr. Gaurav said.

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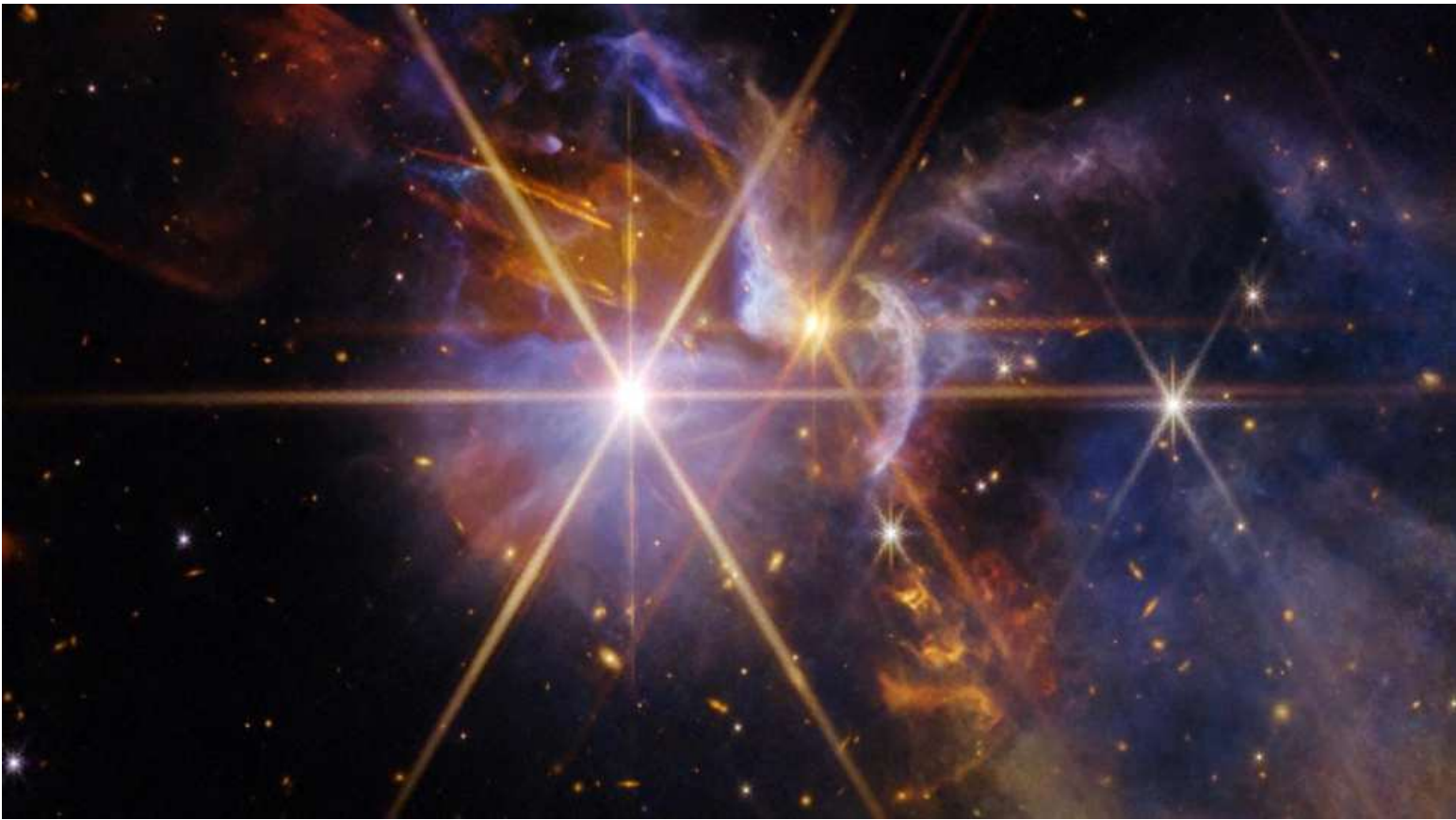
THE GIST

The study documented milk yield in three bovine categories and found that high temperatures, in combination with high humidity during July and August “significantly reduced milk production”

It found that indigenous cattle were more tolerant to heat stress, and maintained homeostasis, with more advanced evaporative cooling compared to buffaloes

The text concluded that indigenous breeds should be conserved as “reservoirs of climate-resilient traits,” and policies must prioritise *in-situ* conservation and farmer-led breed improvement programmes

BIG SHOT



The Webb telescope’s image of the FS Tau star system. FS Tau A, a pair of protostars, is slightly to the left of centre and weighs around half as much as the sun. FS Tau B, the orange protostar slightly to the right, is thought responsible for the red (molecular hydrogen) and orange (polycyclic aromatic hydrocarbons) outflows amid the dusty region. The blue ridges are light scattered by dust. NASA

WHAT IS IT?

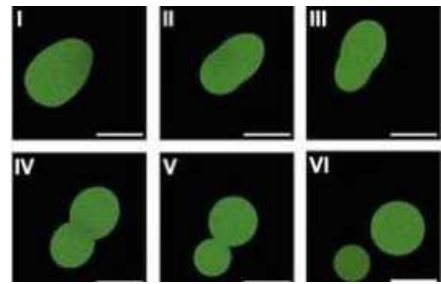
Synthetic cell: machine that could

Vasudevan Mukunth

Researchers from the University of Minnesota have developed a synthetic cell that can grow and divide. The team ‘started’ the cell as a liposome, a small bubble made of fats. Inside was a protein-making system called PURE, which contained all the necessary ‘machinery’ for the cell to turn DNA into proteins. The DNA consisted of 90,000 base pairs.

The synthetic cells ate by fusing with smaller feeder liposomes. The cell’s DNA instructed it to produce a protein called alpha-hemolysin that becomes like a hook on the cell’s surface. The hook grabbed the feeder bubbles and pulled them in, providing the lipids and nutrients the cell needs to expand.

As the cell grew, it used an enzyme called Phi29 to copy its entire genome, then it divided into daughter cells. While the researchers first used mechanical force to split the cells, they eventually engineered a biological way to do it. By making proteins crowd the surface of the cell, they created enough physical pressure to make the membrane split into two. The researchers also proved these cells could undergo selection. They introduced a mutation that



Once the cell grew and copied its DNA, it divided into daughter cells. KATE ADAMALA, ADAMALA LAB

allowed some cells to eat more efficiently. These faster-growing cells produced more offspring than others and dominated the population. “It will, perhaps, provide a compelling argument against those who think there is some immaterial substance in addition to the chemicals that breathes life into material stuff,” University of Exeter professor John Dupré told *The Guardian*. “But almost no scientist now believes this.”

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of voters left out of Sikkim SIR draft rolls

37,724 The office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) said that of the 4,71,018 registered electors in the State as on May 20, as many as 4,33,294 enumeration forms were collected and digitised. The enumeration phase under the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls was held between May 30 and June 28. PTI

Number of pleas filed against EC during West Bengal polls

110 Opposition parties had accused the Election Commission of holding a biased election to help the BJP. The poll watchdog was also accused of carrying out the special intensive revision of the voter list to disenfranchise voters not supporting the BJP. The then CM Mamata Banerjee had pleaded the case herself before a Supreme Court bench. PTI

Amount mobilised by IIFCL for funding infra projects

1,848 in ₹ crore. India Infrastructure Finance Company on Sunday said it has raised ₹1,848 crore by issuing non-convertible debentures to fund infra projects. The issue attracted an overwhelming response from investors, attracting bids worth ₹3,048 crore, representing nearly six times the base issue size of ₹500 crore, IIFCL said. PTI

India's required refined copper capacity addition

5 lakh in tonnes. India will require roughly 5,00,000 tonnes of additional refined copper capacity every five years to keep pace with the rising demand of the metal, International Copper Association India MD Mayur Karmarkar said. He said copper demand is likely to track overall GDP growth and the association is anticipating at least around 9% growth over 2026. PTI

Number of Yemen govt. troops killed by Houthis attack

16 Yemen's Iran-backed Houthi rebels killed 16 troops in an attack south of the port city of Hodeidah, two military officials said on Sunday. The officer said the Houthis briefly took control of pro-government positions in the clashes, which began late on Friday, before a counterattack to retake them concluded at dawn on Saturday. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The real crisis in India's fisheries

Official claims that most of India's marine fish stocks are sustainable should not distract from the continuing degradation of the country's inshore fishing grounds; stronger governance of coastal waters and better management of mechanised trawling are essential for truly sustainable fisheries

FULL CONTEXT

Maarten Bavinck

India has a very large and old marine fishing population. Every day, both small-scale and mechanised trawl fishers go out to earn a living and provide the nation with food.

The Government of India recently released its latest prognosis of the country's ocean fisheries (February 11, 2026). Its press release emphasised that Indian marine fisheries are largely sustainable, suggesting the country has avoided the bane of international fishing, namely overfishing.

Official claims

Drawing on figures compiled by the Central Marine Fisheries Research Institute (CMFRI), the government said that most commercial fish stocks "are in good health". Furthermore, it stated that "91.1% of the 135 fish stocks evaluated in different regions during 2022 were found sustainable." If this assessment is accurate, it would be good news. However, there are good reasons to doubt whether it is indeed correct.

For one, the Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO) is far more reserved in its assessment of the condition of Indian marine fisheries than the Indian government seems to be. India's country profile argues that "India's marine fisheries production reached a plateau as most major stocks are fully exploited. [...] Unregulated access to these fisheries resulted in significant overcapacity, especially of medium and small trawlers that compete over dwindling fishery resources with mostly impoverished small-scale fishers." This message is not half as buoyant as the one published by the Indian government.

I will not dispute CMFRI's conclusions or its methodology for calculating 'sustainability'. After all, most of its procedures are veiled in secrecy. What is known, however, is that compared with many other fishing nations, CMFRI continues to rely primarily on landing data rather than stock assessments.

In other words, it calculates the availability of fish stocks in India's Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) – which includes up to 200 nautical miles (371 km) of sea area around the country – based on what fishermen catch. Even a layperson can understand that finding a certain number of shells on the beach does not necessarily predict the quantity of shells in the sea.

Other nations, therefore, make use of stock assessments at sea itself, thereby calculating how much aquatic life is available in certain waters. This is obviously the more reliable method to determine the health of fish stocks.

The Government of India cannot be blamed for not yet adopting this more costly form of stock assessment. But it does raise suspicions that the race to catch up with China, which is also infecting the fisheries sector, may also be inducing a hidden bias in the figures.

The decline of inshore ecosystems

Among the fishers I have spoken to over thirty years along the Tamil Nadu coast, the consensus is that catches have consistently gone down and that many species that were formerly available have disappeared. The government, however, seems to continue on the path of amplifying fish production figures from one year to the next.



GETTY IMAGES

Overfishing, however, is not the central issue here. The more pressing concern is the decline, if not the destruction, of the inshore benthic environment. Over the past year, numerous fisheries scientists and policymakers have described the inshore fishing environment as "destroyed". What exactly do they mean?

India is surrounded by a relatively narrow continental shelf, where fishing is always the most productive. This continental shelf is broadest in Gujarat and a part of Maharashtra, but remains quite narrow along the rest of the sub-continent.

Generally speaking, one can assume that the territorial seas – a legal category referring to waters that lie within 12 nautical miles (or 22 km) from shore – largely overlap with the continental shelf. These waters provide favourable ecological conditions for commercially valuable species such as shrimp to feed, breed and grow.

But why do senior experts conclude this is no longer the case?

This is a complex question with many answers. Thus, one can point to the construction of dams in major rivers, which disallow land-based nutrients from entering the sea. One can also point to the ongoing destruction of mangroves, where fish breed, and to pollution that is entering the sea from various industrial, agricultural, and urbanising sources. Many scientists, and fishers too, point to such changes to explain the decline of fisheries. These factors obviously affect the inshore fishing zone more than they do distant waters.

Mechanised trawling and its cost

One of the many factors contributing to this decline is the dramatic and largely uncontrolled expansion of mechanised trawling.

It is good to remind ourselves first of all that semi-industrial trawling is not an Indian fishing method. It was introduced from abroad around 1960 and has since

expanded to gigantic proportions.

According to the same government press release, India now has 64,414 mechanised fishing vessels. These numbers are growing day by day as there are practically no restrictions on new entries. Moreover, existing vessels are continuously being extended and fitted with more powerful Chinese engines, enabling them to catch even more fish.

This oversized fleet of mechanised trawlers ploughs the inshore seabed in a continuous fashion. In heavily trawled areas, this results in a decline of all animal and plant life. It has also resulted in major conflicts with the numerous population of small-scale fishers who see their livelihoods imperilled. The problem is that regulations to protect the inshore fishing zone are almost non-existent. Yes, mechanised boat fishing is closed for two months every year, so as to allow for the rejuvenation of fish stocks. But the main tool to prevent unwanted trawling – the prohibition for mechanised boat fishers to operate within a geographic zone of 5 NM – lacks forcefulness.

There are two main reasons for this. First, coastal States lack sufficient staff or craft to patrol the inshore waters. Second, governments have precluded fishers from playing a helpful role in management. The result is that the ecology of the inshore fishing zone is continuously being degraded, and all fishers – small-scale and mechanised – are being pushed out to the offshore and the deep-sea fishing zones.

Rethinking fisheries policy

The Indian government is optimistic about the potential of deep-sea fishing and is encouraging fishers to make a shift. But the question is whether that potential, which is also being tapped by other fishing nations, is as bountiful as expected. The FAO estimates that "at best, only a marginal increase can be realised through exploitation of deep-sea resources."

More fundamentally, India's current fisheries policy is wasting the enormous potential of inshore waters. For one thing, it imposes extra expenses for fuel and technology on fishers so that they can actually travel to more distant waters. At the same time, it is closing its eyes to the dire need for proper management of inshore waters. Aside from addressing the problems of marine pollution, it also means curbing, if not reducing, mechanised boat fishing. This is more than a technical issue. Mechanised boat fishers, by way of their numbers and their political influence, now often stand in the way of proper management. This is witnessed, for example, in the case of the Palk Bay, which is located between India and Sri Lanka. There, the Indian fleet of mechanised boat fishers now pirates Sri Lankan waters to the detriment of small-scale fishers on the other side of the international border. Ownership of the island Katchatheevu does not make any difference in this respect.

The way forward

While the government's assessment paints an encouraging picture of Indian fish stocks, a more fundamental concern remains. The larger issue is that fishers, scientists and policymakers continue to decry the degradation of the inshore fishing grounds. A viable and truly sustainable fishery can only be realised if governance of the so productive inshore waters improves. For this, the government must adjust its perspective. This is in line with FAO's view that: "Strenuous efforts are needed at federal and state levels to upgrade the country's capacity to manage its marine fisheries." In this context, CMFRI might also want to devote effort to studying what the condition of the benthic environment is actually like. This would provide a basis for deliberating on the best way forward. (Maarten Bavinck is emeritus professor of coastal resource governance, University of Amsterdam)

THE GIST

Food and Agriculture Organization presents a more cautious assessment of India's marine fisheries than official claims, warning that many major fish stocks are already fully exploited.

India's fish stock estimates rely largely on landing data rather than direct stock assessments, raising questions about how sustainability is measured.

Expanding mechanised trawling and weak enforcement of coastal fishing regulations are placing increasing pressure on inshore ecosystems and small-scale fishers.

With Vaibhav becoming the youngest-ever male cricketer to don senior India colours, a quiz on young Indian champion athletes

*Many leaders
are expected
to jump ship*

Anand is a wiry kid who is capable of lifting people twice his weight.
My daughter, Sunitha, has the wiry frame of a sprinter.
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